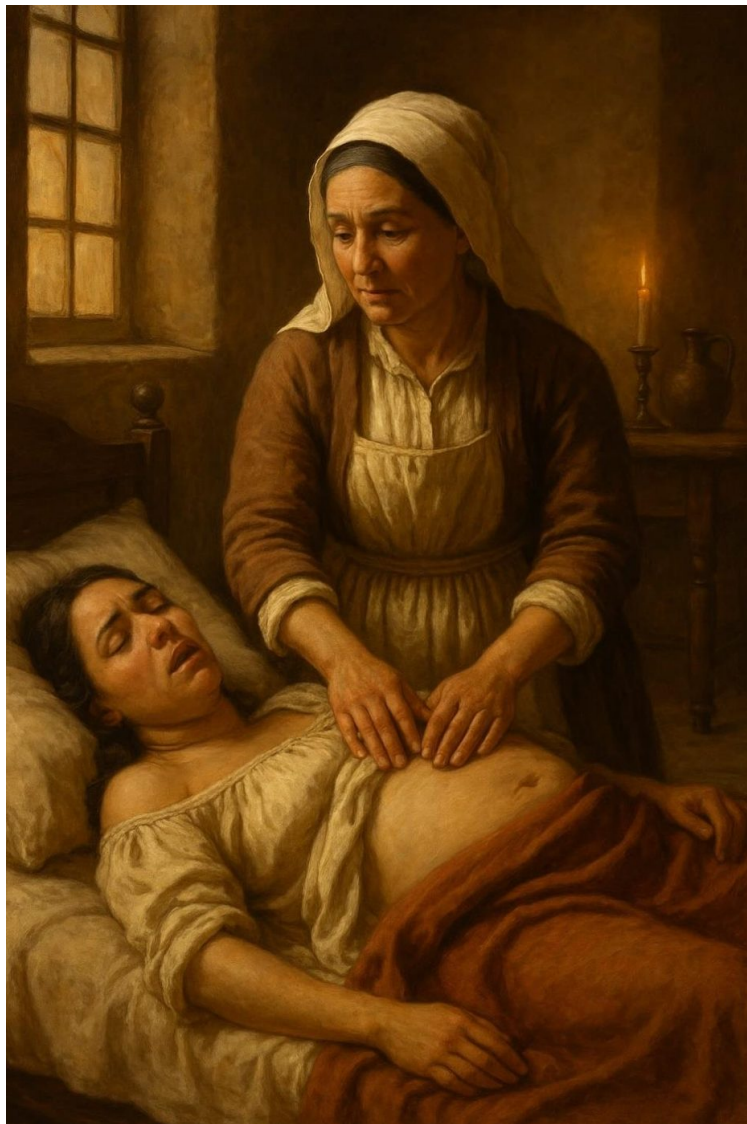


FREDDY CÓRDOVA OSSIO

TALES, STORIES AND DAYDREAMS OF MAMA MARTINA AND ANTONITO



Legend is the most delicate expression of popular literature; it is the enchanting Road of tales and stories, which seeks to escape the vulgarity of everyday life by embellishing it with a dreamed-of spirituality.

*English edition. Translated from the original Spanish, *Relatos, historias y ensueños de Mama Martina y Antonito*. Song lyrics quoted by the author are kept in their original Spanish.*

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INTRODUCTION

This book is not a linear story. It is a weaving of memories, voices and dreams, like the threads on a loom that cross one another to form a single cloak.

In these pages the stories of Mama Martina, a midwife and wise curandera (healer) from the valleys of the Imperial Town (Villa Imperial) of Potosí, live side by side with the dreams of Antonito, who converses with masters of art and of the spirit. They are tales that seem to be fragments of different times, yet they share a single heartbeat: respect and affection for our ancestors.

Each tale is a moment held still: a setting, a walk, a workshop. They are scenes that do not seek to be fully explained, but to be felt, because in them lies hidden the root of who we are.

And so memory and dream intertwine to remind us that the past does not die, but goes on teaching in the voices of our grandparents and in the dreams of children.

THE INHERITANCE OF LOVE

My name is Antonito. I am the great-grandson of Mama Martina and Abrahán Ossio, a respected healer and midwife and a cabinetmaker of the Valley of Potosí, where I was born. Both were known for a great deal of work, recognized and vouched for by its results and its creativity, and also for being humble and honest people with the folk of the town and with the families of the Spanish miners.

I have always considered myself the luckiest and most beloved great-grandson of all, for being with them and keeping them company in their daily tasks. At six years old I helped in the carpentry shop, and I helped Mama Martina prepare her medicines from herbs and earths. Today we are walking along rocky paths, searching for herbs and earths and learning about them, and talking about her past life: the events, histories, tales and legends from the historical past of our colonial land.

These stories, told by her and by my sister, have in some way strengthened my spirit of struggle and perseverance. Without them I believe I would have failed in all my purposes and in my wish to better myself. Above all, they have made me proud of my family as the bearers of that spirit of struggle and sacrifice. My honor and eternal gratitude to them.

PART ONE

Bearer of Destiny

Chapter 1. THE GIRL OF THE RAVINE

I remember that my parents worked gathering ore in Atocha and Tasna and sold it to the ore buyers, and my mama Martina sometimes sold vegetables she got in Cotagaita and delivered the babies of many of her comadres. We were very happy; I never lacked for anything. Then one day we got up very early, and they told me to bring my dog Tobías. In a loud voice my tata said: we are going to travel very far, we need our Tobías to protect us, we will go to a quieter place to work, we can't stay here any longer. They charged me with a whole list of things... to look after myself, to protect myself from other people, always to be polite, willing, attentive and respectful with my elders, not to lie, and not to pick up anything that wasn't mine, even if it had been thrown away. I don't know why they told me this over and over again.

We set out in the small hours of the morning with bags on our backs, carrying our provisions for many days, water, coca tea, and a metal grinder for the ore, which we loaded onto the llama. Our Tobías walked ahead. It seemed like a fiesta, the way he barked and jumped, as if he could sense freedom. We marched for days; my feet were sore. We went on along narrow, stony paths, the trail of the miners and their llama trains, resting now and then, until we reached the foot of the river, and across from it stood the town of Atocha, where gold and silver were mined. We went on about two leagues farther and stayed in the ravine, a place where we could pick ore (apallar) and search freely and find what we were looking for... This rocky ravine was surrounded by paja brava, yareta and churqui grown very tall. We sat down to rest and then walked the rest of the way. I set about clearing the ground to spend the night, and gave the llamas food, after tying them up and securing them so they wouldn't bolt. We ate our provisions and drank a little coca tea; Tobías shared our food with us. The weather was sunny and a little cloudy, with an icy wind blowing, but it was bearable. After chewing coca, my parents went off to find a place to settle and grind or sift the ore, silver and gold. Whenever they sat down, it was a sign that they had found the right place, the one they were looking for. When I saw this, I had to set about finding food. In the time we stayed there I saw many wild guinea pigs

(cuis), and turtledoves that came to drink water at the stream that ran close by... Tobías, Tobías, come on, let's go, I want you to help me hunt. As if he understood, he nodded his head; he was like a person. He jumped and barked and barked, as if to say, what joy!... Don't bark, don't bark, I kept telling him, to make him hush. We kept walking, until suddenly we heard the flutter of a dove flying off a short distance. We followed it: it will tire, it will tire. Tobías, follow it, I signal to him, and you can catch it. He runs like a gazelle, silently, and I wait a little while, and then I hear him barking, and soon he appears with the dove in his mouth. I stroke him and run my hand over his head: very good, Tobías, now we have something to eat today. We kept looking, and after a while we saw a cuis running. Run, run, Tobías, don't lose it, careful it doesn't get into its burrow! It was amazing. Tobías was so agile, a true hunter; he caught it and brought it to me and laid it in my lap. Bravo, Tobías! I gave him a kiss and he began to bark and jump. You have your food too. Then I cut the little necks of both, and a lot of bright red blood came out, which I drank from both of them. We shared with Tobías; I told him, open your mouth, and you should have seen how he enjoyed it, licking himself right up to his nose. Next I had to look for firewood or yareta. A few steps away I found some; it was quite dry. I tied it up and carried it on my back to our resting place. I took some evenly shaped stones, made my kjoncha and laid the yareta and the firewood in it. Striking some stones that we had gotten from the miners, which make sparks and fire, I managed it. I ran to the river with my clay pot, fetched water and brought it to a boil for the dove and the rabbit, so as to skin them and pluck the feathers right away, because if you don't do it at that moment it's hard; they turn stiff. I took out the insides of both and gave them to Tobías with all the giblets. I told him: eat, eat as if it were the last time. I ran a stick through the dove and the cuis and then cooked them over a slow fire, turning them every so often. Soon you could smell the roasting meat. I also put the little potatoes and chuños in another pot to boil, and a while later everything was ready to eat. When the sun was going down, that was when my tatas, which in Quechua means my parents, were due back. Martinita, we're home! What joy to hear them. Tobías announced their safe arrival with his barking... Mamitay, papituy, how happy I am to see you... Martinita, what have you done? We smell meat, where did you get it... Martinita tells them the whole story. Help yourselves, it's nice and hot, eat this little dove and the rabbit... How delicious, dear daughter, we are so pleased. Give me a little coca tea and we'll rest. We'll tell you that we've found a good little vein, so we have to work hard, and for that we'll

get our kokawi (provisions for the road) ready so we can leave very early. I want you to take care of yourself; don't let Tobías wander too far, so that he can look after you. And so a few days went by. They always came back happy, and they said again that in two days we would go to the town.

The next day she wakes to the barking. Her parents had already left. She went on with the routine of finding food and preparing it, but she felt a weight on her chest, as if something were happening to her. She also heard Tobías howling. What's wrong with you, what have you seen, what are you sensing? She heard the little birds, the Parachí Dios, singing on and on, which they usually do when a very heavy rain is coming; I had learned that from my mother. Some time passed and it began to cloud over. The weather turned ugly and cold, with a lot of wind and black clouds; it looks like a real storm is coming. Time went by, and every so often a sadness, a despair, came over me. In my little head I say: let them come, they must be cold and hungry by now. Please, Lord, take care of them, I beg you... In the dark sky there are flashes of lightning with a deafening noise, and a few drops of rain. Please let them come, let them come soon. A while later I hear barking, which is a sign they are near. They appear and I run to meet them, a little wet. How good that you've come, papitos! I made you a very hot lawita and your little cup of tea, so you can rest afterwards. The thunder and lightning grow stronger and stronger. After we finish eating, a very heavy rain comes down. We cover ourselves with hides, I lie close to my Tobías, and we fall asleep....

I don't know how much time passed.... I wake up with my head very heavy. I heard desperate shouting and weeping, people crying out: look, look at the state they're in, they're all dead, dead... I didn't know if I was dreaming. I couldn't move, neither my arms nor my feet; they seemed paralyzed. I heard what they were shouting, but I couldn't open my eyelids. I heard them saying: don't go near, don't go near, they're charged, the grown-ups are badly burned, and the little girl and the dog have no burns, but they may be marked by the lightning's charge. With great difficulty I manage to move my arms and feet. She's moving, she's moving! the people shout. Don't go near, it's very dangerous, it could kill us!... Sleep comes over me again. I don't know how long I stayed in that state. I wake up to the barking of my Tobías, who was licking my face and whimpering.... I ask myself: what has happened to me? I don't feel well, my head seems hollow. It seemed I was still dreaming. I came to my senses because Tobías was tugging at my clothes. Only then do I

think: this is not a dream. What has happened to me? Where are my parents? Have they already gone to work? I don't see them. Just then a palliri appears (one of the women who pick ore by hand): Daughter, we thought you were dead and we were very afraid to touch you, because of the danger of the lightning that left a charge in you. You've been lying here for about three days beside your little dog. We have to tell you... those people... were your parents. Yes, yes, where are they? They've died, the lightning killed them. No, no! I screamed and screamed. Calm down, daughter, we buried them over there, we couldn't leave them like that. I didn't know what to answer; I could only weep and weep. It seemed like a lie. All I could do was scream and scream, and hear my Tobías howling. Only then did I kneel down, hugging my dog, and scream and scream: Lord, why have you done this to me? You leave me alone, alone. What am I going to do now? Where am I going to go? You told me you would always be with me, and now who am I going to cook for, dance for and make laugh? Lord, give me strength to bear this punishment... Don't cry, daughter, it is a sorrow for us too..... We found this bag beside them and we want to give it to you. It's very heavy; surely it has their ore and other things for grinding. We'll leave it with you. Look for us whenever you need us. We're also leaving you this bit of food and tea so you can have something. And they walked away, disappearing into the horizon.

In the morning I go to the place where my parents' remains lay, as if someone were guiding me.... I get there, and on my knees with my hands on the earth, I asked them, weeping: why have you abandoned me? But I am sure you will always be at my side, protecting me. I am leaving this place; I will follow the path you guide me on. I take with me the charge you gave me and the bag, to face my days... As she leaves, she asks herself what has become of our llama. Tobías, let's go look for it. They spend some time walking among the stones and the paja brava, and there ahead we find the llama on its knees, eating shrubs. Come on, come on. They load it with all its things and her parents' bag. They walk and walk through different places, heedless of time, until they reach a mild town full of greenery called Cotagaita... to face another reality, alone with her Tobías....

PART TWO

Protection and Guidance

Chapter 2. THE MEETING OF TWO SOULS

Martina was barely eight years old when destiny tested her with its hardest lesson: to face the road of life with nothing but her own strength. She learned early that from loss, too, springs the root of love and strength.

Hunger and fear were her only companions, but so were hope and the strength to work. From then on I learned to sell my vegetables, toasted broad beans, kispíña and medicinal plants, and many people came up to me and bought what I had, and so I was able to feel a little calmer. My Tobías kept me company in all this; he never left my side for a moment... A long time passed in this routine, days of great sadness, but always with the strength to fight and keep going, with the strength and hope her parents had instilled in her...

One very sunny morning, under a clear sky, with the song of the little birds flying from tree to tree as if to show me their joy, an old woman with silver hair suddenly came up to me. Her voice made me tremble, and I had the feeling that I had always seen her or known her. She said to me: Child, I am interested in everything you have; how much is it? I'll buy it all... But, señora... She would not let me answer. Tell me how much it is and I'll pay you, don't worry, don't be surprised at what I'm telling you, don't hesitate... I did not know what to say, and she handed me the money I named; it was the whole week's sales. Shall I carry it to your house... would you like me to? Very well, child, let's go... Tell me, what is your name? She repeated, what is your name? And I answered without fear: Martina. Martina, señora, and you? Aurora de la Cruz. My parents brought me from Toledo, which is in the Old World, and I stayed. I live alone and devote myself to healing and to attending births. And where do you live?... In the countryside, and I sell food and these plants and earths that my mama used very often. And so they walked a good stretch. My heart was pounding at all this and I could not explain it; I walked as if I were outside myself. Suddenly we stopped, and the señora, with great delicacy and a very slow step, showed me that from this street the next one was close by. This is my house, she said: it had an immense gate and a white-painted front. If you like, you can come

another day. Come, keep me company, you could be my companion.... Her voice was so refined and respectful. It was a very large and luxurious house. If you wish, and if you trust me, go and bring your little things, whatever you have... I was left very surprised and thoughtful... something drew me to her, as if it were the spirit of my parents. Suddenly a certain affection and attraction was born in me, as if she were of my own blood. I told her: I'll go to the countryside and come back.... And on the way it was as if a light shone on me; something gave me such confidence. I had nothing more to think over twice, and I came back the next day with the little I had. She welcomed me with joy and open arms, kissing me on the forehead: You will be my daughter, which is what I have always wanted. You are very beautiful, with mischievous blue eyes. This is your home, and I offer you this room so you can settle in. You will not leave; you are part of me... I did not know what to say or how to answer.... It was as if I were dreaming, and finding the peace and calm of being beside my beloved parents... As the shadows of night came on, I remembered, and grieved over, the loss of my faithful friend, my dog Tobías, who had kept me company for years of my life, ever since I lost my parents... Later that night I heard Doña Aurora's voice. She asked me: Do you know how to say the prayer.... the one we say when it is time to rest, so as to wake up with great strength, hope and faith in the Lord for the day, so that things go well for us... I answered no... That's how it is... listen, and when I am away you must always say it... I listened closely to how she prayed, with such faith that tears even came to her eyes, and she asked that I never be separated from her and that my health be kept safe. From that declaration I truly knew that she loved me, that she did so from the depths of her being... She told me: Tomorrow I'll leave very early and I may be gone two days; you make your own meals, and don't worry about me.... But señora, let me go with you. No, no. Later on you'll tire of our work.... Some days after she returned she asked me: How do you know about medicinal plants... My mama taught me to use them for some illnesses and pains. Very good, we share the same calling, so it won't be hard for you to come out with me and see a lot of people. First of all, I want you to put on these clothes that I bought some days ago; that way I will feel very proud to introduce my dear daughter to the people I know, and they will recognize you and respect you as such. What she declared surprised me, and I felt much more affection for her. From that moment on she taught me how to recognize and cure the ailments of each one of her patients; some of them I already knew from my mama's guidance. In this endeavor I was with her day and

night, going with her to the countryside and on her rounds. She was very responsible and punctual, no matter whether her patients were country people or townsfolk.

One day she took me to see a boy, perhaps about 12 years old, lying on some sheepskins, his gaze lowered, his eyes without shine, his little face sad, pale and utterly wasted, his little hands bony, his eyes sunken, as if he had never eaten or been given any food. This boy is a treasure.... she repeated it with such tenderness... The woman in charge said he had been like this ever since his papa died in the mine, and his mama was sick in the lungs. The doctors from the mining camp had seen him; he responded to nothing. Doña Aurora said again, almost sobbing: It is as if I were standing before my own son.... I feel his suffering deeply. She asked the woman in charge to prepare food: Right now I want you to bring me a jug of goat's milk, and give it to him every day. Son, she said to him in a soft, sure voice, offering him her trust and affection, I'll take you home, I'll care for you as if you were my beloved son. She kissed him on the forehead and on his little hand, and, closing her eyes, she repeated three times: Lord, Lord, Lord, give health and strength to my child. As if it were an awakening, a soft voice was heard saying: Thank you, my señora, thank you. And, trembling, he tried to get up, and with a smile he hugged and kissed her, and tears could be seen on his cheeks. That instant made my whole body shudder, and I saw her weeping with the boy; my heart broke and I could not hold back my tears. This showed me that she was a very sincere, honest and humble woman, who offered inner peace to everyone who came near her. From that moment the boy began to receive his milk and his care. As time and care went on, he could be seen to be happier and to have hope of living; the moment the boy saw Doña Aurora, a shine came into his eyes and a smile expressing his gratitude. We came back many weeks later and saw him walking; with firmer little steps and open arms he went to the señora, kissed her on the forehead and said thank you, and may the Lord repay you... What an improvement, simply from offering him spiritual strength and trust; that was the medicine that set him on the road to his cure... At that instant, without thinking, it came from the depths of my being, and I said to her: Mamita Aurora, what have you done for the boy... She answered me slowly... and I saw the tears welling from her leaden-gray eyes: Thank you, child, how long I have waited for that to come from your mouth and your heart, for you to call me mamita.. for me it is a joy and a blessing... Child, I want you to know that the soul is like the plants... the first needs

trust, love and hope, and the plants need water and sun; without these they wither and die..... You are the breath of my life... and the light of my hope...

Many weeks went by. I had grown used to her manners, her ways; it seemed I had always known her. We ate together and laughed over some mischief or other, above all about her patients. One quiet night, as we sat drinking cedrón tea: Child, child Martina... I felt a kind of shiver run through my body, and at the same time peace and security. What could she want to tell me? Has she grown tired of me, or what can it be? She spoke in a calm but sure voice: You have never told me about your parents or where you come from. Tell me, and if you'd rather not, I leave it up to you... I never told anyone, and no one ever asked me, what happened to me. I remember that my papas worked picking ore at my Atocha-Tasna and sold it to the ore buyers, and my mama sometimes sold vegetables she got in Cotagaita and delivered babies for some of the comadres. We were very happy; I never lacked anything. And one day we got up very early, and they told me to bring along my dog Tobías. In a loud voice my tata says: We are going to travel very far, we need our Tobías to protect us, we'll go somewhere else to work, we can't stay here any longer. They charged me with a whole list of things: to look after myself, to protect myself from other people, always to be willing, attentive and respectful toward older people, not to lie, and never to pick up anything that isn't yours, even if it has been thrown away. I don't know why they told me these things over and over again./1/

We set off before dawn, with bags on our backs, carrying food for many days, water, coca tea, a metal grinder for the ore, which we loaded onto the llama, and in front went Tobías, our dog. It seemed like a fiesta, the way he barked and leaped, as if foretelling freedom. So she told, with great sadness and weeping, what had happened in her childhood.... We marched for days on aching feet, along narrow, stony trails traveled by the miners and their llamas, resting now and then, until we reached the banks of the river, and across from it stood the town of Atocha, where gold and silver were mined. We went on some two leagues further and stayed in the ravine, a place where we could glean ore (apallar) or search freely and find what we were looking for. And so she went on with her story and the sad end of her parents... weeping and repeating: Why did this happen to me? I dreamed of them, and of growing up, of having a future without sadness, tears and hardship. The only one I shared this suffering with was my dog Tobías, who later left me as well, and that was

another time of suffering, and I had little hope of going on



living...

Doña Aurora, full of admiration.... Child, you are a heroine, brave, with a star that guides you. For that reason I choose you, and you have appeared on my path. I do not regret it, and I say it again: I call you my daughter. You are the owner of, and the one responsible for, everything we have. We will always be together until the end. For me it is a joy and a source of pride to have you at my side; it is what was missing in my lonely life... The days went by, and time, and between the two of them grew such closeness and respect that no one could doubt they were a happy family....

From the meeting of those two souls was born the strength of a tradition that can still be breathed in the memory of the valleys... Doña Aurora, in their moments of rest and with peace in her heart, would tell her all the stories of her grandparents and parents, so that she would keep them in mind and they would serve her as experience over the course of her

life... ..

THE SLAVE TRADE AND SLAVERY IN THE AMERICAS

The transatlantic slave trade in colonial times was one of the most lucrative businesses, making fortunes at the cost of the misery of Black people. That is why the trade in Africans is described as a true industry. It is estimated that from 1481 to 1517 thousands of slaves were sent to the New World by order of the Spanish hierarchy, and that its ships carried approximately three million to South America. They arrived in Cuba, Brazil and the Río de la Plata, where they were offered to buyers who put them to domestic work, hauling loads and mining. Before reaching their destination they walked like pack trains, tied together or in wooden collars so they could not escape.

The slaves were indispensable to the overall progress of these countries. Coming from the west coast of Africa, from the Congo, Nigeria and New Guinea, they were carried in special ships [slave ships], also called Coffins or Tumbeiros. These names expressed the character of all those mercantile expeditions, because only half of the Africans who had left Africa arrived alive in America. They traveled tied up and crammed into the ships' holds, without the most basic hygiene, since they had to relieve themselves in the same place, and without proper food. In these conditions, out on the high seas, those Africans fell prey to starvation, dehydration, gastrointestinal infections and hunger; packed together and exhausted, they died in the midst of their companions. Some, to escape their mistreatment, threw themselves into the sea and drowned or were devoured by sharks.

In the trade in Africans the price or cost varied a great deal. For example, in the Río de la Plata a Black slave was sold for 80 pesos fuertes, while in Potosí, a true devourer of human beings in its mines, he was resold at a price of 300 to 400 pesos; this high price benefited the Basques, the only ones wealthy enough.

At first the few, costly African slaves were put to work on haciendas, in the silver mills (ingenios) and in artisans' workshops, and some served as overseers or foremen; if they had certain qualities that interested their masters, they held a favored position compared with the Indigenous workers.

The true and principal pioneer owners of slaves were the religious orders. The living conditions of enslaved men and women were harsh. On religious properties the Africans were kept under constant control so that they would not form families or become pregnant; their condition determined that of their descendants, and the child of a slave woman was born a slave. The slaves were subjected to every kind of labor; young women were treated entirely as sexual objects. Women and men over 45 were given their freedom, by then sick and without strength and often without family, and they joined the mass of the unemployed and the street. Many of them were taken in by relatives or sheltered by acquaintances until their old age, and others died on the outskirts of the town.

Over time they organized themselves in order to stay closer together and so preserve their customs, beliefs, language and so on. From this arose the famous Cofradías, or brotherhoods; among these the first were those devoted to a saint, such as San Benito, and they were watched over by the Church.

Black people served according to the labor needs of the European colonists, on agricultural plantations and in mining; they formed the base of the Ibero-American economy and, through it, the support of the Spanish and Portuguese crowns. For every African who reached these shores alive, mortality was so great that five perished, as we have already mentioned, from starvation, diarrhea, dehydration, suicide or various punishments.

ON THE LIFE OF BLACK PEOPLE IN COLONIAL POTOSÍ

My grandfather used to tell me that many of the Black people brought from Africa were made to work in the mines, and they could not bear the cold and died. In those years, as a result of a snowfall that lasted 8 days and a very piercing icy wind, and because the houses gave so little protection, 14 Spaniards and 18 Black slaves died.

Years later, the Black slaves who worked at the furnaces of the Royal Mint (Casa de la Moneda), as silver smelters and coin minters, were kept under a system of strict confinement, above all to prevent the theft of silver and the street fights between groups of Africans and Indians. In 1645 it was discovered that the enslaved Black women of the town came into the Mint to fetch water from the fountain, and that it was they who carried out the silver the slaves handed them. When discovered, they

were subjected to harsh punishments such as 100 lashes. Many often escaped because of the mistreatment, the hunger or the pains they felt in their legs, which they found very severe; many of them became paralyzed, and this was grounds for dismissal. Even so, they often went to the Mint on various pretexts to get close to the overseers and overpower them, and many times they caused their deaths, which they considered the only way to seek their freedom. Otherwise, from the complications of their ailments, they died in the gloomy, dark and cold dungeons of the Mint, which had windows barred with steel.

The Black slaves had a wealth of energy and daring. They carried out their masters' wishes, playing many roles, as hired killers, torturers, executioners or poisoners, and many, men and women alike, were used as sexual objects. From this arose the tantanacus, the forming of couples accepted or not by the family or the group, as in the case of the Basques.

Many of the Africans who worked in the mines or in the Mint complained of intense pains in their limbs, their head or their abdomen; blows they received accidentally at their work caused these ailments. Some died suddenly and others were left permanently disabled, while others endured the pain to keep on with their tasks and so avoid the overseers' lashes.

Over time, and in different periods, mixtures arose between whites, Blacks and Indians, and the CASTAS were formed: social systems in which a person's status is assigned for life. Therefore, in societies organized by castas the different strata are closed, and the individual must remain in the social stratum into which he was born. The following castas are identified:

A white and an Indian produce a Mestizo

A white and a Mestizo produce a Criollo

A white and a Black produce a Mulato

A white and a Mulato produce a Cuarterón

An Indigenous person and a Black produce a Zambo

A Mulato and a Spaniard produce a Marisco

A Castizo and a Spanish woman produce a Español

A Chino and an Indian woman produce a Salta Atrás

A Salta Atrás with a Mulata produces a Loba

A Marisco with a Spanish woman produces a Chino

A Lobo with a China produces a Jíbaro

A Jíbaro with a Mulata produces an Albarazado

An Albarazado with a Negra produces a Carbajo

A Calpamulato with a Carbura produces a Tente en el Aire

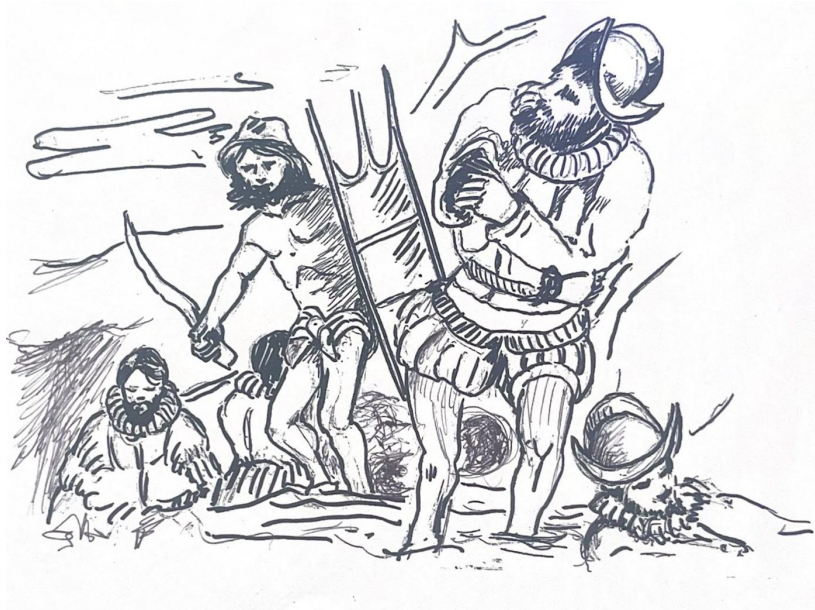
A Tente en el Aire with a Mulata produces a No te Entiendo, etc...

A very interesting example is the parentage of Marshal Andrés de Santa Cruz: his parents were the criollo Santa Cruz Villavicencio and his wife, a slave named Juana Basilia Calahumana, daughter of the Cacique of Huarina, 52 years of age, whom he bought for a price of 150 pesos [Ref. Crónicas potosinas].

Of their customs there remain, among their dances, the candombe, and among their dishes, mondongo, achuras, locro and mazamorra.

These stories show us that the pursuit of wealth has no borders and no scruples whatsoever. Every right of a family or community is ignored; people are kidnapped without regard for any feeling, for love, or for their responsibilities as members of a family. There was utter abuse and, above all, arrogance toward those peoples whose traditions and customs were disregarded. They were treated as true animals; under the influence of religion it was said they had no SOUL, and therefore they should be treated as beasts. Neither age nor sex was taken into account for the work they had to do. They contracted many illnesses, from infections to deficiency diseases, and even more because of the altitude: circulatory problems, gangrene, sexual abuse, and they were abandoned when they no longer met their masters' demands or economic interests. This is a true lesson from our forebears, and one that in the future will be regarded as an element of struggle and liberation.....

THE WAR OF THE VICUÑAS AND THE BASQUES



The thriving economy of the Villa Imperial, built above all on mining, drew the interests of the viceroyalty and the hopes of many groups, families as well as mining enterprises. It also drew the ships that carried Black people, Arabs and even former convicts, for this was a way of getting rid of murderers and of prisoners jailed for all sorts of offenses who would otherwise have had to spend years behind bars; and since it also brought in a great deal of money, the authorities decided to grant concessions to the navigators and to some of the pirates who came to the Indies and to the Villa Imperial in search of treasure. Above all it was the Biscayans who were the most eager and the most favored in the concessions, and who cornered the silver mills, the mines and trade in general.

These facts were the cause of the dispute and the clashes known as the War of the Basques (Vascongados) and the Vicuñas, the latter represented by the Indians, criollos, mestizos, mulatos and others under the leadership of Alonzo de Ibáñez. The fighting took place in the Pampa de San Clemente and broke out every day, in brawls, sword thrusts and assaults, and it would last three years. There was no end to the hatred and the feuding between the Basque settlers and the so-called peninsulares, Arabs, Italians and Dutch, and the criollos descended from Spaniards, who were called Vicuñas. The economic and social situation grew tenser and tenser. The natural deposits of silver and tin brought a flood of people who wanted to work and make their fortune, but the economic, social and political dominance of the Basques, who formed a powerful group that acted as it pleased and on a whim, and who carried

themselves with great pride and arrogance, bred hatred among the population, including the mitayos, the enslaved Black people, and even people of their own Iberian stock, and this led to quarrels and feuds.

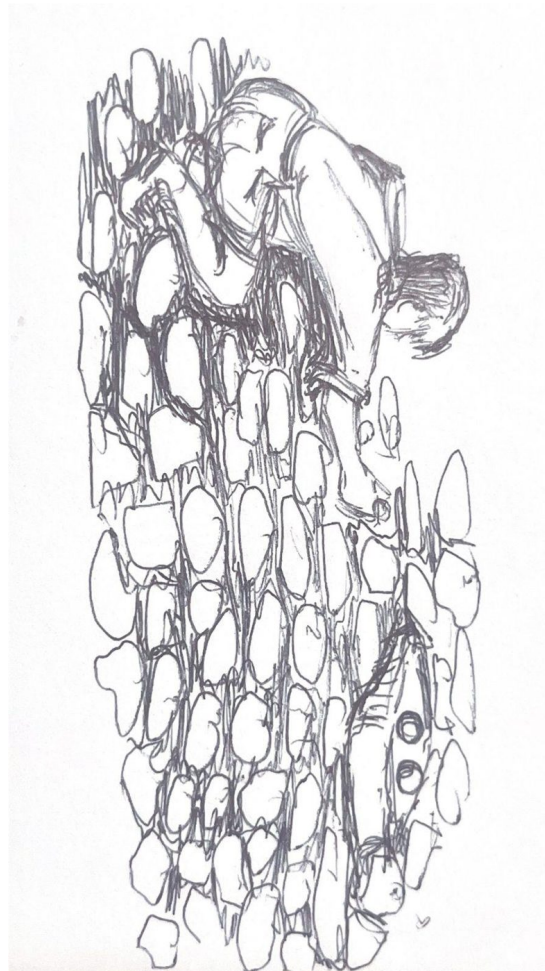
These events, which also came together with a decline in silver production, caught the attention of Don Francisco Toledo in a surprising way: the murder of Don Juan de Urbieto by the Vicuñas on June 8, 1622. The following night the Basques patrolled the Villa, saying in their own tongue: "Whoever does not answer in Basque must die." There were skirmishes on both sides, and even an attempt at peace on June 22. After that the war went on with its ups and downs, favorable at first to the Vicuñas, warriors and soldiers of fortune more used to handling weapons. The Basque leaders found themselves forced to leave Potosí and settle in La Plata, where they were close to the authorities and where they had strong ties through the silver trade. Upon the arrival of the Viceroy of Peru, Philip IV, the Spanish monarch, ordered Diego Fernández de Córdoba to put to death some forty Vicuña leaders between 1624 and 1625. Later an attempt was made to bring peace through the marriage of the daughter of Don Alláname to the son of Castillo, one of the captains of a band of Vicuñas.

In spite of this, the feuding went on, and above all the Basques persisted in their great ambition to seize the greatest share of property, offices and mines.

This economic inequality and abuse of power turned into repression against their leaders, who were executed by hanging from the balconies of the Plazuela del Gato (Valentín Avicia). This conflict lasted a long time, and it seems important to stress that, in the feelings of the people of Potosí, there was never any room for neutrality or for giving up their rights. The massacres and lootings of Basques on November 6, 1623 could barely be attested, because the witnesses (children, women and Indians) feared deadly revenge. The skirmishes continued, and Corregidor (magistrate) Manrique was wounded by a bullet in his own home; because of this attack, both groups apparently reconciled in an act of agreement held in the Church of San Francisco.

THE GAME OF CACHINAS

Acts of violence and killings had broken out between the Basques and the criollos, on the one side because of the excess of abuses and privileges in the granting of mining claims and market stalls, the exploitation at work and the mistreatment, and because some grew rich while others grew poor. The complaints reached the ears of the Viceroy, the Marqués de Guadalcázar, who had on some occasion tried to talk with them and calm things down, with no result at all. This time he came up with a very different way for those two groups to face each other, a peaceful one, in which fathers, sons and whole families from both sides, Vicuñas and Basques, would take part: a very popular and challenging game, the game of cachinas (glass marbles). The active players would be the children of both groups, from the different mining districts. For this, prizes of great value would be offered, and the winners would pledge to put an end to these quarrels and differences....



The game of cachinas is played with little glass spheres brought from ancient China, which each player kept in a chuspa (a small woven

pouch). It requires a “table,” which is a completely flat stone belonging to the cobbled street, which the whole town enjoys in its entirety; the stones are river-rounded, and many of them shine in many colors in the sun’s rays because they are flecked with traces of pyrite, silver and gold. In this game both opponents must place on the table the PARADA, which is two or more cachinas, and then, both standing about five meters away, they throw and try to knock them off the table or get as close as possible. Whoever is closest has every right, if he can, to knock them all off and leave one for the end. Next he must give chase to the enemy, which is the opponent’s cachina. To do this the player has to crouch down and, with the thumb and the middle and index fingers of the right or left hand, flick the cachina to reach or touch the opponent’s. Many times the marbles are hidden in little caves or holes where they are placed on purpose, and it depends on the player’s skill or dexterity to reach them. If one misses, the other gives chase, and once he has touched it, his target must be what remains on the table; when he knocks it off, he is the winner, and that is how the bets go. In championships, only 12 cachinas are staked.

Among the prizes to be awarded, which were very tempting, so that surely nobody would want to miss this chance, the first was a chuspa of kidskin embroidered with gold and silver thread, holding 25 gold coins and 50 silver ones; the second was offered 5 gold and 20 silver; and the third received 15 silver coins and an alpaca poncho. Among the registered participants were the villas of Cantumarca, Miraflores, Caracoles, Munaypata, San Pedro and Pampa San Clemente, and the one chosen to stand for the Villa San Pedro was José Luis, the fourth child of Doña Catalina and Primo. He had been put forward by his uncle, the Maestro Rafael, who did work at the Corregidor’s hacienda. But before the event he had to compete against other contenders, and many doubted him because he was very small, in age and in height, compared with the other contenders, who had some Spanish or European descent. Happily he had no great trouble, eliminating them with the greatest ease, and you could see the joy and happiness in José Luis’s mischievous smile when he qualified. The joy and happiness spread to the grandparents, Abran and Martina, to his parents, Primo and Catalina, and to his brothers and sisters, Nelly, Jaime, Ricardo, José Luis, Charo, Evita, Jorge, Martha and Estequita, a large and very close family. All of them, in great jubilation, congratulated and kissed the winner, the grandparents proud of their children. And Ricardo, a counselor as

always, told him: it is better that you go and rest and stay calm; tomorrow you must be very focused, and above all thinking about how you will face Pancho, who is one of the best of the group. It is only natural for a boy of that age to want to chase his dreams; he even begins to imagine what he wants to be when he grows up, and he works very hard to get what he wants, in this case to be champion. He gave all his free time to the game until the black mantle of night arrived, the very last moment, and so he sharpened his reflexes, his strength and his aim. His rivals criticized him a great deal for his age and his size, but he did not even listen to them; he ignored them and walked past whistling his favorite song, "Quisiera que volviera los días de mi infancia." He was encouraged by his brothers, Ricardo and the eldest, who kept telling him: you know, brother, how to face your enemies and the public; you must not be afraid, for you everything is easy; breathe deeply, and when they look at you, look them straight in the face without lowering your head, and you will see that they will start to be afraid of you. And he would say: yes, little brother, just pretend you are playing with me, but mind you, I only give you chances, don't forget that. José Luis, seeing his rascally face, would die laughing and say: oh, little brother, you and your illusions, you think you can beat me, that is impossible, it's only a dream. Even so, he could not quite hide his nerves. Night came, bitterly cold, and every now and then he warmed his hands with his breath. When they got home, his sister Nelly, always attentive, was waiting with a lawita and some buñuelos with cane syrup, along with a cinnamon tea so hot that it gave off a thick steam that vanished at once, like a child's breath. After finishing, completely satisfied, having received a soothing meal, and with no strength left at all, they went to their beds and fell into a deep sleep.

The appointed day arrived with a radiant sun and the energy of the mountains, as if foretelling that something good and dreamlike was going to happen, or as if it wanted to tell us that something had happened to its companion, the moon, which was slowly disappearing on the blue horizon. The field chosen for the contest was the little Plazuela del Mitayo, fitted out with stands that rose as high as the eaves of the roofs, which gleamed in their yellow and brown colors, and with balconies full of flowers set aside for the families who owned the most prestigious silver mills, where the authorities and the representatives of the two groups in conflict were seated. The night before, as if the weather wanted to help, a torrential rain had fallen and splendidly washed the fine cobblestones, leaving puddles of water here and there, through which slid threads and

shapeless beads of mercury that marked out the playing table. This was a river stone, completely flat and level, like the tables made of Carrara marble belonging to King Charles V, which gleamed and stood out among the other rough rocks. These formed very special natural hiding places that looked like caverns, as if they had been made especially for an escape.

Suddenly the shrill blast of a bugle was heard, announcing, for all to see, the prizes to be competed for, which hung from Arabian horses, finely groomed and specially dressed, stepping very rhythmically to the beat of a drum: a large bag of kidskin embroidered with silver and gold thread, full of gold and silver coins, and other silver vessels holding silver and gold coins, all of them minted at the Mint, the historic building that was built by Indigenous and Black workers over a period of 20 years. Next, dressed in suitable clothes and attire, the participants or competitors came in and were cheered with frenzied applause. Then a deep, powerful, guttural voice was heard officially reading from a parchment the pledge and challenge of each one of them, steeped in pride and determination, and above all the duty to show gentlemanly conduct in this event, which was a true battle, and calling on the public to respect the players and both sides, wishing them, in the name of the Viceroy, good luck.

The organizer of the event formed two series of four teams each, in which the winning player would move on to the second and third rounds; whoever lost would compete no more, and the winner would go on. You could see great dedication and care in the players, and their supporters, full of intense emotion, cheered on their representatives. At moments it seemed that fights were about to break out that might even come to weapons: the Basques with their harsh tongue, and the Vicuñas with Castilian, Arabic and, most mischievous of all, Quechua, shouting, Cochiy- Cochiy Jáselo, khan ancha jatun kanki, dios ninchi yanapasunkha (you are very great, our God will help you); on the other side, rattles and castanets. And with that enthusiasm they reached the end of the matches, and the true finalists turned out to be a big lad named Francisco de Ortega and, most surprising of all, the brilliant José Luis, small in size but great in his character and his play, spurred on by the teasing shouts of Evita and Charo, who cried: go on, little brother, we are behind you, and we promise to make you the bread and jam you like best, go on, little brother! The contest began, and it was a real battle. The Basque started the game and with an accurate throw hit the paradás on

the table. With an air of arrogance, Ortega, scorning the little José Luis, left on the table as his *parada* a violet *cachina*, as if he wanted to show his hatred and resentment toward those called blue-blooded. The next throw was one of retreat and escape, and so the duel began, with skill and with steely nerves. With a stealthy look, studying it from different angles, he tried to touch it, but unfortunately the missed shot landed two or three feet away, in a little cave, and a shout was heard saying that not even San Rafael could reach it. José Luis, with a calm and serene gaze, studied it from different angles; at times his look seemed that of a lynx or an eagle. He readied his delicate little wrist and his thumb and index finger, squeezing the crystal, sky-blue and red like a flame of fire, and launched it in an arc, and incredibly it made a sound as if a lightning bolt had struck a diamond, and the high-pitched shout was heard: I got you, I got you! He raised his arms to the sky as if giving thanks to the Lord on high, and then went on toward his target on the table, which lay very far away. The public was left speechless, in total silence, at the sight of such skill. Then it was Francisco's turn to give chase, and in the end he did not manage it, because the clever José Luis cleared the table. And so the following matches went on, and they reached a tie in the number of games won, leaving the final. You could see how tired they were, but their spirits were high. The public, very nervous, did not know who would win; they shouted and cheered both opponents. Finally, in one of the moves chasing Francisco, José Luis was left with a very long shot, and you could see on his little face that he was in great pain: sadly, the nail of his thumb was broken and almost bleeding. Straining hard to bear the pain, he threw the *cachina* and managed to touch it, and finally he turned to the table and, with admirable skill, launched it like a rocket that flew to its target, knocking it off the table, and you could see and hear him: I won, I won! Crying and laughing at once, he was seen spinning around on the cobblestones without rhyme or reason. He was the champion, the champion! And the public roared: Joselin, you are a hero, an incredible boy, how did you do it? With this victory we have shown them that we are strong and persevering and that nobody can beat us. Congratulations, little one, you are a wonder! All the people, acquaintances, and above all those from the neighborhood, ran and shouted: we are the champions, nobody can beat us! Those on the other side, with sad faces, stood in a striking silence, not saying a single word; the unfortunate thing for them was that they had to stay on that stage for the awarding of the prizes, and one of those in charge was none other than the Viceroy, the Marqués de Guadalcazar, who appeared with other dignitaries. It was

astonishing to see the public shouting with such emotion. The three champions appeared. The third prize was placed in the winner's hands, to a shout; the second went to Francisco, who showed a certain displeasure, but once he felt the coins he calmed down. Finally, an astonishing cry: José Luis, José Luis, José Luis! The voices were so loud that they surely carried over the whole Villa. And to see the little boy so full of joy, he seemed to be seized by a spirit of happiness; he only laughed, and tears ran down his rosy cheeks. He cried and cried, all the more when they showed him the chuspa embroidered with silver and gold thread, into which they dropped, with a tin tin tin, the gold and silver coins, and hung it over his right shoulder. The Viceroy told him again and again: you are very brave and persevering; despite your age and your injured finger you have won the victory, which is a source of pride for your countrymen, your parents and your brothers and sisters, who feel very proud. Congratulations, congratulations.... In a voice broken between laughter and tears he repeated: thank you, thank you, thank you very much, sir, and thank you all. And once more the shout rang out like thunder: champion, champion, champion! At that moment he was showered with streamers and confetti, and amid this outpouring of joy he headed back to his beloved little plaza. Immediately the Corregidor summoned two representatives of the feuding groups to sign the pledge of non-aggression and peace; otherwise they would be punished and stripped of some of their contracts for mining claims and for the Rescate,



Jaime and Ricardo, the elder brothers, were very busy and could not be at the awarding of the prizes, which was considered the most important part, because they had set aside those days for some mining work and, above all, to go with their friends Alfredo Buhezo, Willy Varela and Walter Morales, who were devoted to searching for the traces, the trail left behind by the people close to the richest miner of all, Francisco Rocha. Rocha had always boasted of owning brilliants, jewels, diamonds and gold and silver coins, and many times he had promised the townspeople of the Villa that he would pave the streets with silver, just to obtain the rank of gentleman. This was one of their goals: to find, by any means, the TREASURE OF ROCHA. They would disappear for several days and turn up with pale faces, thinner than before, and for their parents this was a great worry. Every time they were asked, they said they had been in the Mondragón area, where Varela's father had his fields of corn, broad beans and potatoes, which he took to town to sell and to eat. But that was only an excuse. As soon as day broke, their thoughts were centered and fixed on being in the area of the Devil's Bridge, since according to rumor that was where one of the objects of

their search was to be found. Others were drawn instead by the tapados, the hidden caches or chests that the Spaniards had stashed away when they left Potosí for a time, and who very often, for many reasons, never came back, so that their treasures were forgotten. These riches were the focus of attention not only for them but for many fortune hunters, just as it had been in the days of mining and silver. For them it was a way of improving their economic situation, which had always been a great worry for their parents. They saw with their own eyes how their parents earned their living with great sacrifice and risk, risk because of the work they did, and their pay did not justify the effort they made: they worked the whole day long in the mines, and their fortnightly wages were barely enough for food and a little clothing. Sometimes they repeated what they thought: education is good, but it does not answer our needs.

Speaking of the Devil's Bridge, a place where the local people prayed as they crossed, especially as night fell, there surely came to mind one of the events that the old people of the area used to tell, and from which it takes its name, the result of a story that happened in this place.

So as not to take the wrong paths, as had often happened to them, the band of explorers would ask for the help of one of the farmhands, who knew even the most unimaginable corners of the region; they called him Albertico. And just as they reached the Devil's Bridge, he would begin to tell one of the legends of the region, about the love of two young people. They say that on hearing these words the whole group would gather around him and pay attention as never before, far more than to their parents' advice. He began, like all legends, by saying: there was a very handsome young peasant who fell in love with a very beautiful girl, the daughter of the corregidor, and they would meet in secret. But one day they were discovered by her father, who threatened him and laid down the following demand: if you love my daughter, you have to pay me her dowry, which is this amount of silver, within a year; otherwise you will never see her again. I am doing this because I have heard that you work hard and well, without forgetting what family you come from. The time starts from today. In this very short time the suitor promised to keep his word, and to do so he began to work at many things, as a miner, a helper, a carrier of ore. Up close he saw how the workers did their work facing many dangers, cave-ins, falls into mine shafts, and often being trapped in some of the workings; and most surprising of all, they ate almost nothing, they only chewed coca, which let them work without tiring. And on one of those afternoons he saw them bring out the remains

of a miner killed in an accident, and heard the endless weeping of his little children and his wife, which truly stirred a deep sadness. After a year, having earned the dowry, on the day he was returning with what he had earned to fulfill his agreement with his sweetheart's father, he set out with his donkey and came to a ravine that he had to cross. Suddenly the sky grew dark, as if foretelling a conflict. Thunder crashed along with lightning that lit up the whole place, and a torrential rain began, with the roar of waterfalls and the rumble of rolling rocks that numbed the senses. And he asked himself: what am I going to do now, how will I get to the town? It is impossible to cross. What can I do? Her father will not believe my word, and it will be his reason to forbid me to see her. In his despair an uncontrollable rage came over him; he kicked the rocks and pounded the edge of the gorge, weeping and shouting amid the lightning and the terrifying, unstoppable noise: what can I do now? I feel helpless and I have no hope left. And finally, into his confused mind, with no other choice or option, came the idea of asking the devil for help, and in a loud voice he said these words: [I would even hand over my soul if he would help me build a bridge. At that very instant, to his great astonishment, the devil appeared with a great crash and a certain smell of burning sulfur, and, standing before him, in a hoarse voice that grated on the ears, with an air of arrogance and self-assurance, having heard his request, he said: what do you want from me, why did you call me? You know that if I do it, it is on one condition: when I finish what you ask of me, I will take your soul. The young man told him his wish, to build a stone bridge, and without further ado he accepted on that condition: if it is finished by dawn, before the rooster crows, my soul will be yours. I agree, but keep it in mind,... before the rooster crows... A deal. In his extreme haste the devil cut the stones and set to work as if he were dozens of workers to build the bridge. The young man, calmer now and at peace, began to reflect and realized the mistake he had made, and he asked God for help: Lord, forgive me for this act. I did not know what to do in my hurry; my anxiety made me commit this madness. Please help this poor son of yours who is facing this calamity. And suddenly he perceived a sign, white like a radiance: the archangel Saint Gabriel. At that moment there was a clap of thunder and a flash of lightning, and he wondered: could this be the sign my Lord is giving me? At that moment he felt his body tremble, and an inner peace, no longer the despair that had gripped him. Suddenly there were signs on the horizon that dawn would soon arrive. He saw the devil hurrying to take the last stones to finish the edges of the bridge, and then, unexpectedly, many angels appeared who prevented

the devil from lifting the stones and setting the last stage in place to complete it. And far away the shrill sound of the rooster's first crow at dawn was heard. The demon, thwarted, spitting sparks and thunder, vanished into the infinite, saying: I will not forgive you.. In this way the young man saved his soul, and the bridge was left unfinished, but it no longer kept him from keeping his promise of the silver. And so his pledge was fulfilled, and the couple's dream came true: the two young people married and lived happily for many years, with several children.

THE EXPLOITATION OF INDIGENOUS PEOPLE IN COLONIAL TIMES

After the genocide of the Indigenous peoples through the wars of conquest, the Spanish conquerors went on to impose a widespread enslavement of the Indigenous peoples. Many peoples did not submit to the Spaniards until they had been defeated militarily, and even among those who accepted Spanish rule, not a few ended up rising in revolt for many reasons, one of them being the merciless exploitation, and the diseases brought over and passed on by the conquerors. The Spaniards decided to stay, imposing a long-term state policy, and, more for economic reasons than out of any concern for human good, they adopted, in a derisory, insulting and degrading way, a policy of "protecting" the Indigenous people as free labor for the encomiendas, since land with no one to work it lost all its value, to the detriment of the encomenderos and of the Crown's tax interests.

1. The Spaniards used the labor of the Indigenous Americans in many kinds of work: as servants on their haciendas, as field hands, as helpers to the priests, and, hardest and most dangerous of all, in the mines. That work was assigned to young men, who stayed down there a long time, and if they did not die, they came out very sick or disabled. The Indians held in encomienda paid their tribute and worked on public works, building structures such as town halls (cabildos), jails, cathedrals and churches. The priests devoted themselves to instructing them in the Catholic faith, in groups known as Doctrinas. Many of these priests denounced the abuses to the Crown, such as Friar Montesinos and Friar Bartolomé de las Casas, who managed to reach the throne itself and lay this abuse before it.

The account of the Spaniard Reginaldo de Lizárraga, in 1605, says that the Cerro Rico of Potosí is like the center of the Indies. It is the wealth of the world, the terror of the Turks, the curb on the enemies of the faith and

of the Spanish name, the astonishment of heretics, the silencing of barbarians; and nations such as Italy, France, Holland and Germany are rich thanks to this treasure, with the wealth that has come out of Potosí, and even the Turks keep in their treasury bars of gold carried from Potosí.

They work deep inside, in the shafts and rugged tunnels, where the darkness is perpetual and one cannot tell at all when it is day or when it is night. There is only a perpetual mist, and bitter cold too, and foul air alien to human nature. These were the conditions of the Indigenous people's hard labor.

The ore is extremely hard and has to be broken out with blows of an iron bar. Then they carry it up on their backs by a ladder made of three twisted strands of cowhide. A man climbs out carrying two arrobas, tied in a cloth across his chest with the ore it holds on his back. They climb three at a time; the one in front has a candle or small lamp tied to his thumb so that they can see, and so they climb a distance of about 300 meters, a horrible thing (as José Acosta relates in his account of the Indies of 1590). This exploitative labor, together with the military campaigns waged between rival factions, drained and diminished the labor force in the region, and it is here that the importation of enslaved Africans begins.

CONCERTAJE. - Another form of exploitation of the Indigenous people. It consisted of a contract between the cacique (chief) and the master whereby the mitayo Indian became the master's servant for a wage that was not equal to his work, in exchange for which the master fed him while he was in his service, until he died.

PART THREE

The Path and Dignity

Chapter 3. DOÑA MARTINA, THE MIDWIFE

The years went by, and she became the inseparable companion of Doña Aurora, who taught her the whole practice of caring for the sick and attending births. Out of love and affection, Doña Aurora offered her surname to her as a daughter... and from then on she was called Martina Vidaurre de la Cruz. From that moment she felt very proud and immensely secure, no longer an orphan, though she never forgot her parents, who in spirit had set her on this path. The whole town admired her for her kindness, her help and, above all, her beauty. She cared with all her love for Señora Aurora during her illness, Martina came to regard her as her true mother; shortly afterward she died and left her entire estate to Martina. Martina carried on with the same work, always keeping the lady's respect and good manners... And so time passed, and she formed her family with Don Abrahán Ossio, a cabinetmaker and carpenter with many trades and occupations... They had met when he came to Señora Aurora's house to do carpentry repairs, over a long time, and in this way they formed a friendship that kept growing.

Mama Martina became a pillar of her community; her days and years passed among the sick, births, remedies, stories and tales of the past of great importance.

Whenever she spoke of it and told the story, she could not hold back her tears. It hurts me so much... every time I treated him I would hear the cries and screams of my son Jaime, the ñawilo, Cata's son. He had a wound on his leg and his arm that had appeared after a fall. I would wash it with herbs, and bits of his flesh and little pieces of bone would come out; I had to remove them until it bled, and then I applied a poultice they taught me long ago, called dragon's blood (*sangre de drago*), which comes from some palm trees of the tropics. I treated it every five days, and it stayed that way for a long time. And my heart would break when Antonito, still very small, crying, would shout at me: *mamita*, please, don't let him suffer, the pain is so great, for God's sake heal him... And so, after many years, he was healed by applying that poultice; and yet it left in all our minds a very sad and painful memory. In every one of Mama Martina's stories beats the strength of the earth and the memory

of the valleys of Potosí.

Very often people arrived in the village asking where Doña Martina lived; usually they were seeking her care for someone's health. We need her urgently... She is not at home; the whole family has gone to Chagrahuasi, which lies south of the village. They are busy making furniture in the Villa of Viceroy Toledo, and Doña Martina is attending the women of the corregidor (magistrate) Don Ventura Santali, and of Quiroga, Ortega and Gambete, who are the owners, mercury refiners (azogueros); all her children are helping, Rafael, Catalina, Esther and Herminia... Go on, go on... And they did not know that the women asking for her were relatives of Don Félix Ortega, who were summoning her to Potosí, to the silver mill (ingenio) of Huayra; he was an azoguero, a producer of silver... They reached the place and spoke with Mama Martina. Please, Doña Martina, we beg you to come to Potosí. Don Félix is very ill, and the Spanish doctors have given him up for lost; they say they have exhausted every known form of treatment. Please come with us...



Such was the worry and the sense of responsibility that they called Don Félix's cousin, the surgeon Juan Ortega, well known and respected by those around him. On seeing and examining him, he ended by saying: there is nothing to be done. How could you have let him get into this state? Look, he can't even breathe... that anxiety, his mucous

membranes completely purple, the great effort to breathe, a thoroughly toxic state. This illness is fatal; all you can do is pray and ask the Lord to protect him.... Hearing this, the family, deeply worried and in despair at seeing him in that state, almost dying, did not know what to do. Amid the voices and the weeping came the advice of one of their close comadres: to see and consult Doña Martina, the healer (curandera), who had great experience and who, above all, the neighbors said, had saved many lives. For God's sake, see him for me, do something to save him, we cannot bear this suffering any longer... weeping and weeping. Hearing this outcry, she knew it was an emergency. Without further delay Doña Martina heeded their pleas. She had not expected this from that family, but she had so great a spirit for helping, for being at the side of anyone who suffered pain, that she paid no heed to their class or origin, and she went in haste after putting her remedies in order, all of them made from herbs or animal fats. When they arrived at the silver mill, the great gate opened, and behind it a very young Black servant greeted them with a bow and led them down a corridor floored with finely worked brick blocks and lined on both sides by arches that reached as far as the door of the sick man's room. It was very spacious, adorned with very elegant furniture, and at the far end, in a very wide bed, he could be seen, attended by a girl whose head was covered in white and who wore a bib-apron. Doña Martina, deeply focused and calm, first of all observed and listened with great care: his posture, the labored breathing, the moaning, the drooling. Don Félix was completely unconscious; he did not respond to her greeting or to her questions, nor to the pressure she applied to the side of his shoulder. His skin had a marbled look, his eyes were deeply sunken and ringed with dark circles, his lips were purple and cracked, his breath putrid, and beneath his chin was a large swelling that reached down to the base of his neck, the skin taut, shiny and hard, very sweaty and hot, above all at the neck and throat. Please, I ask you, lay a straw mattress (payasa) and a soft phullu (woven blanket) on the floor and bring Don Félix down onto it, so that I can work better. She sent almost everyone out of the room, leaving only the sick man, and asked for a little ground quinoa, salt, egg, ground coca, honey and a cloth of vicuña wool. She began to pray while she prepared a poultice containing everything she had asked for. Over a brazier, in a small pot, she mixed the ingredients and warmed them over slow embers; it was dark green and sticky. She spread a layer a finger thick over the cloth and, taking it in her two skilled and gentle hands, applied it softly to the swollen part of his neck, with him sitting up. At that moment a terrifying scream of death

was heard, one that set their ears ringing, and he fell backward onto the hides spread on the floor, expelling from his mouth a putrid, very foul-smelling mass of blood and pus, which was cleaned away at once. They laid him on his back with his head tilted back and turned to one side, and in that instant his bulging, congested eyes could be seen, giving the impression of a fatal end; and then a calmer, deeper breathing was heard. But Don Félix wore a different expression: a pale face, bluish lips; he did not respond to his wife's cries, he was completely limp, and it even seemed that he had died. Amid the weeping, the moaning and the cries of despair of the neighbors and of the mine workers of Doña Luciana, his wife, Doña Martina, with a word of encouragement that seemed almost magical, said aloud to everyone: stay calm, he is going to get well. How... it can't be... the best doctors have treated him without any result, and now it seems he is sleeping, he is breathing better, he is not agitated, we can see he is improving, this is a miracle, a miracle... All the onlookers heard this and were astonished, bewildered by this outcome. In the doorways and around the neighborhood there were murmurs of sorrow and resignation, because they did not believe in what she had done. Again, in a calm and commanding voice, she said: don't disturb him, and when he wakes up give him this preparation as a tea... and she withdrew... When the doctors learned that he was being treated by a midwife, they said: it cannot be, it is an insult; above all, she has overstepped their authority and deserves an exemplary punishment. They arrived on the scene, and worst of all, they had not been notified of what had happened; they were very angry to learn that he had been treated by someone else. They criticized and fumed, saying: how is it possible that, over our authority, you have brought in a healer who neither knows nor understands our art? We are the ones who know, and we cannot consent to or accept this. The wife listened to this protest, calmer now, and with a spirit of satisfaction and certainty she confronted them and made it clear: it is my decision, doctors, and I want no comments from you. I made that decision; she came at my pleading and insistence, nothing more. You doctors, in your meetings, urged me to resign myself, and said that your knowledge and wisdom had no answer, that there was nothing more you could do. You drew on your experience and wisdom, and it was exhausted. What could I do as a wife, facing such misfortune and sorrow?... The doctors were left perplexed, frozen and astonished by this answer.... Afterward Doña Martina, her face shining with spiritual happiness, silently and gratefully thanked her God for the help He had given and, above all, for guiding her with His holy

hand. In silence she said to Him: a thousand thanks, a thousand thanks, my Lord, for giving health and life to this gentleman.

Doña Martina, completely renewed, her spirit strengthened and with greater drive, went to the Amoladera and Laca, mine tunnels belonging to the ladies Luisa and Petronila Vázquez, where she took an active part, at great risk, in the terrible epidemic of Intestinal Fever that broke out there, with signs and complaints of vomiting, fever, diarrhea, spasms and death within a short time. In this way it decimated the population of Potosí, especially the mining population, with the fatal consequence that work came to a standstill, and with it the supply of gold, silver and other minerals. So severe was this epidemic that of the 160,000 inhabitants the Imperial Town (Villa Imperial) of Potosí had at that time, 60,000 perished in the short space of the ten months that this scourge lasted. The plague was also marked by swelling of the feet up to the middle of the body; in others it appeared in the arms, the neck and the legs, above all in those who arrived on ships from Asia and Europe, and they died within a short time. The weakest could not endure a single day of suffering and pain, and the townspeople claimed it was a divine punishment... The so-called cholera was marked by continuous fever, repeated vomiting and abundant watery stools, which came again and again, up to 12 times, followed by spasms and cramps in the legs and arms, and then by screams that little by little fell silent until the sick lost consciousness. Their faces were pale, their eyes sunken, their skin wrinkled; they were utterly wasted, their lips dry, until they were completely exhausted and died soon after. The other group of patients had high fever, delirium, abdominal pain and nausea, most notably a yellowish color of the eyes and of the whole body; some vomited blood and passed dark, tarry stools, and the belly was very painful and rigid. Shortly afterward they raved incoherently, went into convulsions and soon died, many of them in the streets, in the mines, and others in the camps.

The faithful, gentlemen, mulattos, mestizos and Indians, talked about it; others wept and murmured in their native tongue: this is a divine punishment from the Pachamama; she is marking us with a punishment for our sins and the wrongs we do. The whole population organized a pilgrimage through the streets of the city. At the front went more than five thousand Indians in two rows, carrying very heavy crosses on their shoulders; with them went others from the confraternities and convents, who claimed that the only way to ask forgiveness for the sins and errors

committed by themselves and the townspeople was to offer up this personal suffering and pain with prayers and weeping, and in that way they might win pardon from the punishment being dealt to them. They whipped their chests and backs with leather cords from whose ends hung nails and sharpened bits of iron, until they bled, enduring this martyrdom for the sake of others. Behind them followed some two thousand Spaniards, barefoot, their hands tied behind their backs and their heads covered in ashes, marching in two rows; in the middle came a hundred Spaniards, followed by the Franciscan fathers and the religious community that lived in Potosí, all carrying lit candles in their hands, and torches accompanying the Holy Christ of the True Cross (Vera Cruz). It is said that this was the only way the plague that was crushing the Villa Imperial could be stopped or brought under control. Because of these events, everyone's faith led them to the church, and that is why I want to tell you these stories and events of the past.

THE CHURCH OF SAN FRANCISCO

The Convent of San Francisco was one of the first temples where the Immaculate Host was adored, by the sons of the Seraphic Father, Father Morán, in the year 1547. The founder of the first church was General Pedro de Hinojosa, a conqueror of Peru and a captain of the rebel Pizarro. He later went over to the royalists, fought as a general against the Pizarrists, and was rewarded with the mine of Potosí, where he was appointed corregidor. He was later murdered in his home in 1553 by the followers of Sebastián Castilla. It was he who requested the presence of the Franciscan brothers in Potosí.

The church progressed quickly: in 1550 one of its wings was consecrated, and the first building was entirely finished in 1552. On March 15, 1626, the most productive silver mills were destroyed by an unexpected flood coming from a lagoon. A year later, in 1627, the Villa Imperial went through another of its worst catastrophes: the bursting of the San Ildefonso lagoon, which flooded the whole town with such force that countless Spaniards, parishioners and, of course, slaves and Indigenous people died; some were never found. More than 4,000 people are said to have died, and it destroyed many houses and buildings, among them the church of San

Francisco, above all the Small Cloister. Finding themselves in this situation, the friars were not seen for many days, and some said they

had perished in the fury of the waters. They reappeared utterly haggard, with the look of deep dejection; they even lamented and wept, powerless in the face of that disaster. The damage was enormous. They did not know whether their tunnels and underground passages, built with great sacrifice and where many Indians and Black people had perished, were all flooded. After thinking and thinking, eager to restore it, they found themselves obliged to turn to many wealthy families to raise some funds. This news reached the ears of the richest miner in Potosí at the time, the *maestre de campo* (field marshal) Antonio López de Quiroga, who needed certain favors from the Church, since he sought a title of nobility that the Spanish Crown kept denying him, and he demanded and pressed this petition again and again. Quiroga agreed to give the friars the help they needed, on the request that he be recognized as founder of both the convent and the church, and on condition that he have a place in the crypts of the church where he and his family could be buried.

Years later Dr. Don Pedro Vásquez de Velasco laid the blessed cornerstone; the plan was to use all the material, and above all the stone blocks, of the church that had been brought down by the waters of San Ildefonso.

The flooding of the San Ildefonso lagoon was regarded as a divine punishment. Sadly, that rancor still ran in the veins of the factions of the Vascongados (Basques) and the Vicuñas, and the clashes began again. It was then that the Viceroy, the Marqués de Guadalcázar, who had been undecided until then because he did not know exactly who was in the right, decided to take matters in hand and somehow calm or pacify these social groups, set against each other in street battles and divided by economic and racial motives, which had bred such intense and lasting hatreds. He tried in some way to bring these two groups together peacefully, and with that aim he sought out their leaders and spoke with each of them, identified the causes and reasons for the conflict, and offered certain favors to both groups. They were left somewhat satisfied, though not persuaded out of the quarrels and hatreds so deeply rooted in them, but they agreed to keep a period of peace and harmony. To this end he called an event that would gather families, businesses, authorities and the townspeople in general to take part in one of the most popular games, played above all in the neighborhoods and by every social class, which had been brought over from the poor quarters of Spain: the game of cachinas (glass marbles). On April 29, 1625, at last one could perceive and feel that peace reigned among those who

remained of the Vicuñas and Vascongados, who went back to their mills to work and to extract silver and tin (information taken from the book by Edgardo Caballero and Berna Hausberger).

THE HOLY CHRIST OF THE TRUE CROSS

One Friday morning in the year 1550, at the entrance doors of the Church of San Francisco, the Franciscan Fathers found a cedar box in the shape of a cross. They opened it at once, and inside it was... the venerated effigy of the Lord of the Holy True Cross (Vera Cruz). It was believed then that angels had carried the box there and that the image was the work of heavenly spirits.

As the years went by, a certain Martínez y Vela, in his history of the Villa Imperial, refers to the following.

The presence of the Lord of the Holy True Cross, found in the cedar box, created a very serious legal conflict over who owned it, involving the trustees Don Melchor de Escobedo, Don Ramón de Trujillo and Don Alonso de Rodríguez, and a lawsuit with the priests of the Mother Church (Iglesia Matriz), who wished to move the image to their own church. Once they even tried, and got halfway, and to everyone's surprise the next day it reappeared at the doors of the Church of San Francisco. Finally a council was formed with the confraternities, stewards and notaries to decide where it should stay, and then Viceroy Toledo stepped in and settled the matter with an ordinance. Although he had been a skeptic, he changed abruptly the moment he saw that miraculous image, whose fame had spread throughout Peru and even further: it was a divine gift, a holy relic, which no one should meddle with. He believed in its miracles, and therefore it was to be enthroned in the Church of San Francisco.

All these events overwhelmed his superstitious spirit and filled Viceroy Toledo with wonder: its face, its hair and beard were splendid, natural-looking; he had felt their warmth and softness when he pressed his face and his lips to it, and it left him with a sense of peace and humility. This is the account that was sent to Dña. Leonor Fernández de CORDOVA, an Andalusian lady who lived in Potosí.

Martínez y Vela tells us, with great respect, that sinners tremble before that image, the wicked repent through a supernatural force, and the unfortunate who pray to it find relief from their sorrows. The Reverend

Franciscan Fathers relate that they make relics from the hair and beard of the Holy Christ; once they cut off part of the beard, and miraculously it grew back. The legend adds that every year on Holy Thursday, after the procession, the Franciscan Fathers comb its hair, eagerly gather the loose strands, and then hand them out as relics to all the faithful, so that they may be protected against every evil.

This crucifix, venerated under the devotion of the Holy Christ of the True Cross of Potosí, began to gain so many devotees, and its miracles were so frequent, that they astonished locals and strangers alike. And so, according to tradition, Viceroy Toledo had a sworn report of these events drawn up, which he deposited in the archives of the Franciscan monastery...

THE CÁRCAMOS, OR SILVER MILLS

The techniques for obtaining silver in colonial times were very rudimentary, since those who exploited the silver wealth did so in a precarious way. The method they used, moreover, was not very effective.

At first, as we mentioned, the Spaniards used the method of smelting in clay furnaces. The ore was extracted and then smelted into ingots. Not much was gained from the ores, and burning firewood and yareta, a wild plant of the high plateau, made it laborious work with little profit.

Later, in the sixteenth century, an Aztec who worked with a Sevillian miner, Bartolomé de Medina, brought the amalgamation or patio method. It consisted of grinding the ore, spreading it out in the patio and sprinkling it with mercury, which has a strong affinity for gold and silver. This was a true revolution in American silver mining. The basis of this process was the use of mercury, or quicksilver (azogue), which was mixed with the ground silver ore and left for a few months in great patios such as Huayra. Then this mixture, or amalgam, was washed and smelted, yielding purer silver, and afterward part of the mercury was recovered to be used again. The smelting of this mixture was done by Indigenous people or Black slaves, using furnaces fueled with llama dung and yareta brought from the plateaus, all of it supervised and controlled by very harsh overseers. Huayra had some twenty ore depots and stables for the mules that hauled the loads, and a cascade of spring water built of finely carved stones stacked to a height of 50 feet, from which, with a spectacular roar, they washed the ground ore in the sieves,

where the precious metal was sorted out, to then go on to be dried and smelted.

The cárcamos are the structures of the amalgamation mills, the silver mills (ingenios) of the mercury refiners (azogueros). They were the places where the extracted ore was concentrated or processed, and they also had pits for depositing or storing it. They were generally built along the riverbank, like the well-known Huayra and the other one, the Rivera de Vera in Cantumarca. Besides these works, the ore was crushed to allow greater contact with the mercury, that is, amalgamation, which was the technique used to process the tons of silver that made the European countries rich. (drawing).

The cárcamos were true walls and bridges that crossed lands and rivers, built with the sweat and toil of Indians and slaves, who used their backs and hands as their only tools to haul the massive rocks from the quarries and to mix the earth and lime. Then, under the direction of an overseer, they piled it all up, from the foundations to the channels, which reached a height of 8 to 10 meters. Along these the water flowed until it reached the rudimentary metal screens, where the metals were washed and sorted before entering the amalgamation process.

THE IMPERIAL TOWN OF POTOSÍ



For those who do not know, it is very important to tell that on the 1st of April, 1545, King Charles V, Emperor of Germany, declared in the name of Spain, and of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit, and said in a hoarse, faltering voice: we take Possession of the Mountain, silent as it was, naming the first mine La Descubridora, or Pailaviri, it being the first material wealth to be settled in the service of God our Lord and for the benefit of His Imperial Majesty. And so the Imperial Town (Villa Imperial) of Potosí was founded. This extraordinary mountain stands 5,183 meters above sea level, and its circumference is one league, that is, a circuit of 25,563 feet. Its summit resembled a perfect cone, displaying on its flanks numerous spoil heaps of many colors and shapes, where they work the mine mouths through which the riches of silver, gold and other hidden minerals are extracted and obtained.

At the foot of this novel peak of the Andes, where a river passed, houses were built for the miners, as if by commission. Later, with the arrival of Viceroy Toledo, work began on the Mint, the churches and other buildings, and the town was definitively founded, and recorded in documents, under the name of VILLA IMPERIAL DE POTOSÍ. Seeing how the population was growing through migrants and the native birth rate, by order of Viceroy Francisco Toledo himself, the hydraulic engineers were commanded to build the lagoons of Kari Kari, five in number, using Indians and some Black slaves as laborers. At first the lagoons were waterproofed with cowhides. The water was essential for washing and separating the metal in screens made for that purpose.

At the beginning of the eighteenth century the Villa Imperial of Potosí boasted a hundred thousand souls and many organizations based on mining. Indeed, mining gave the Basques great economic and political power. They were made up of just 80 families, and they took possession of a great number of mines and silver mills, which was creating a monopoly, while at the same time abuses of power were brewing, and ever sharper social tensions arose with the common people in the streets. These economic interests and power struggles reached unbearable extremes, leading to a brazen greed for what they coveted. It meant not only growth in population but also, naturally, attracted every kind of luxury, custom and product, which, according to the Jesuit Father Acosta, could satisfy any conceivable desire in abundance. Potosí certainly had everything: 14 dance schools, 4 fencing academies, 36 gambling houses and 400 recognized brothels, and it also had so many churches per square meter; religion was the foundation for easing

consciences and forgetting the guilt that the riches dragged along with them.

The world's ambition grew as word of so much wealth spread, and a migrant population arose such as had never been seen before in Europe or America. From 170 Spaniards and 3,000 Indigenous people, within 2 years 2,500 houses had been built, housing 14,000 people. After the census ordered by the Viceroy, it was reported that the population growth could not be controlled, reaching as many as 160,000 citizens in the Villa Imperial, of whom 6,000 were Black people, mulattoes and zambos of both sexes. Among those identified were merchants, hustlers, miners, fortune hunters and thieves who settled there. Most of the Black people worked for their masters on the mountain or in domestic labor; the more servants a master had under his command, the greater the symbol of social ostentation. This gave rise to different ways of life, cultures, social economies and religions, which set them apart not only in these respects but also in their burials: Spaniards, priests and their kind were buried in the churches or the grounds around them, while Indians, Africans and Moors were buried near their own neighborhoods, because it was doubted whether they had souls at all; the others, meanwhile, were close to heaven, or else bought themselves a place or plot at the moment of their death.

Potosí truly is one of the great wonders of the world. People lived surrounded by silver, wealth, luxury, ostentation and power. The main square displayed swords brought from Toledo, glass from Venice, linens from Holland, ivory from Africa; there were 36 gambling houses, festivals and bullfights. Along these lines, because of the economic interests and the other factors mentioned above, two very opposed and rebellious social groups arose, as we pointed out earlier, shaped by their backgrounds, influence, origins and so on. On one side were the Vicuñas, recognizable by their hats made of vicuña skin, made up of Indigenous people, mitayos, Andalusians, Castilians and Criollos devoted to work in the mines; on the other, the Vascongados, also called Vizcaínos, of Basque origin and from Burgos in Spain, who seized economic and political power by holding prominent administrative posts, and only they were allowed to stand in elections for the mayoralties and other representative offices. They also took over the richest veins of the mountain and the mercury refiners' mills for producing silver (by the process called amalgamation) between the years

THE ROYAL MINT

Because there was such brisk trade in clothing, jewelry, furniture, and petacas or strongboxes of leather and fine wood in the shops and markets of the City of Potosí, and above all in the sale of silver, tin and gold, the coins produced in Peru and Argentina were not enough to meet the demand. That is the reason for the creation of the new Royal Mint (Casa Real de Moneda), devoted to producing these coins in sufficient quantity for the dealings and commerce of these kingdoms. According to Burzuo, by higher orders of Viceroy Francisco de Toledo, Potosí, that Mecca, was given the honor of being the new site for building the Royal Mint, under the responsibility of the Potosí master builder Jerónimo de Leto, and it was set up in the Plaza del Gato on the 8th of November, between the end of 1575 and 1595 *; it took twenty years to complete, at a total cost of \$1,148,453.6 reales, and it occupied an area of two city blocks, built of lime and dressed ashlar stone and cedar wood brought from the borderlands of Chuquisaca and the Valleys of the Pilcomayo. When it was finished, the King of Spain remarked, in view of the cost of the work, that the building must be made of silver, as Don Alejandro Garland relates in his work *Los medios circulantes usados en el Perú* (The Currencies Used in Peru).

The Mint consists of five inner courtyards and nearly two hundred rooms, laid out and arranged across its almost 8,000 square meters, figures that show the tremendous majesty of this building.

In the entrance courtyard a majestic mask of the god Bacchus stands out. It smiles sarcastically, with an ironic grimace aimed at the Spaniards, as if bidding them to leave the region.

With the trade in Black slaves, the individual became an object of exchange, a piece of merchandise or a working machine. The Spaniards who came in search of fortune brought their African slaves with them to do domestic work or to join their adventures of conquest. Quite different, and much harsher, was the situation of the Black people used as labor in the Mint. They were the fundamental basis of the local and regional economy, working in the worst human conditions, treated like true beasts without souls, facing the harsh weather and intense cold at more than 4,000 meters above sea level. The slaves spent years at the furnaces. The Black man was considered a slave, a living dead man or a ghost, cut off from his land, his customs and his culture. And so he became a hostile and embittered being, because of the hard work he did and the

treatment he received at the furnaces of the Mint. (Historical Archive of the Casa de Moneda)

The first workshops for minting and die-stamping gold and silver coins for circulation were set up by Don José Fernández de Córdova and Don Calixto Moreira (Crónicas Potosinas).

Potosí minted legal coinage from 1574. A first record testifies that 26,531 pesos were coined between the 28th of March, 1574 and the 7th of December, 1575, with one real of seigniorage paid per mark of silver.

The coins that were minted would serve to pay the day laborers, Indians, Criollos and Portuguese, who made up the workforce, and they were marked for use within the Río de la Plata and the Spanish Crown.

The Mint had 12 Black slaves in good physical condition, who worked at the three furnaces that were set up under the charge of the foremen, or furnace masters, Pedro Real, Lucas Martín and Pedro Salazar, each responsible for four slaves. Ref. Crónicas Potosinas, Volume I – Documento histórico Casa de Moneda Potosí – José A. Fuentes.

In those days an unusual bustle could be seen in Potosí, with the arrival of many workers seeking jobs in the new silver and tin mine mouths, while those who had taken part in building the Mint wished to carry on with their labors as mitayos.

A WEDDING IN THE CONVENTILLO

One sunny afternoon, under a sky so completely blue it was as if a painter had laid his brush on it, reaching down to the mountains in a whitish tint, the temperature pleasant and the pure air you breathed awakening a feeling of freedom and joy, so very contagious, a group of country folk appeared at Doña Martina's house carrying bundles on their backs. They asked her to forgive them for surprising her, and speaking in their almost sung Quechua, they said: we bring you these gifts with all our love and respect, to invite you to our village and to ask you (mañakarle) to be the godmother of the casanaku, or wedding, of Anselmo... that is why we brought you this present; if you accept, it will be a pride and an honor for us that you receive it.... Their bundles held all sorts of food: chicken, goat cheeses, corn on the cob, wine, and many kinds of fruit, like grapes, quinces, figs, peaches, pears.... Along with a jug of aloja, a very sweet and pleasant corn drink.

Now tell me, who is Anselmo's bride.... You know her, ma'am, it's Marcela, Jacinta's daughter. Of course, how could I not know her, I was the one who looked after her from the day she was born. She's a good girl, and what can I say about her beauty, and so hardworking, always helping her mama. How lovely, I am all for it and very happy. Everyone there helped themselves and enjoyed all the food and fruit they had brought... Every now and then Agustín would say to her again: Godmother, your presence makes us very happy, and above all the people of the community respect you very much. I'm going to play for you on my charanguita and sing what you like best, that song... pistola en mano, arbolito en miniatura.... Cotagaiteñita... this Agus never gets tired of talking... yes, Dña. Martina... we're done now, we'll be waiting for you at the barn (galpón) on the appointed day. Very well, I will be there with your godfather Abrahán. Yes, Godmother, we'll be waiting for you....

The days went by, and she had the gifts ready: two lambs, a set of plates, spoons and three phullus woven of multicolored wool. The two of them dressed in their best clothes and bright shawls, and when they arrived at the barn they saw many guests, all with their gifts, and it surprised her to hear most of them greeting her and shouting Godmother. Godmother, how wonderful that you're at this celebration... most of them applauded her.... What a feeling of joy it stirred in Don Abrahán's head... Martina, how well they know you and respect you. Not just me, they do it for you too. Yes, really... come on... come on. I just saw the tata cura (the priest) go in, we mustn't be late, we have to be there.... As was fitting, the bride and groom were already at the front, and we had to take our places beside them... The couple, Anselmo and Marcela, smiling, in clothes that stood out for their color and whiteness, a bright pollera and blouse, in step with the happiness that showed on their faces, as if both were bound for heaven, so that no one could ever part them. The priest began by saying: are you sure you want to become a couple and have children, for good? Both, almost shouting: yes, tatay. Will you look after and care for each other when one or the other is sick... yes.... Will you work and earn a little money for your little house, your children and for times of sickness? Yes. Will you respect each other at all times? Yes. Do you swear that you will never separate... yes. Whatever problem you have, call your godparents, and they will advise you or punish whichever of you is to blame. Yes. Before me and our God and your godparents, I declare you Husband and Wife. I place these silver bracelets on you both... give each other a big hug and a kiss....

Applaud the new couple... I bless you, and may you be happy..... The godparents and guests threw misturas (confetti), little wildflowers and colored candies, surrounding the new couple, may you be very happy, they shouted. Soon after the gifts arrived: sheep, goats, pots, llama hides, blankets, hats, ponchos, plates, pots, ladles, jugs of chicha, etc., etc.... let them dance... let them dance, you could hear, like a chorus.

Coming back home, a little tired, to my great surprise I see and hear people crowded together and a tune of music. I see people and musicians in new, brightly colored clothes, with misturas and streamers, and silver jewelry pinned to their shawls and hanging from their ears, flashing like lightning, as they followed along with their rhythmic movements behind a bride and groom. The bride was very beautiful, and the groom, to my surprise, was maestro Anselmo, the watchmaker, who in spite of his limp kept the rhythm, and you could see the joy on his face. Accompanying the band was grandpa Agapito, grandpa Abrahán's brother, with his organ, which he played with astonishing agility and skill. But there behind, I see Uncle Rafael, with his hands and some thin little sticks, playing drums and bass drums, happy as can be. Only now do I understand why he flew out of the house all dressed up,, and everyone there showed a very contagious joy. At the other end you could hear a very melodious voice and lyrics that portrayed the people around him. It was none other than the sturdy young man, holding his guitar slung from his shoulder, Luis Rico, the Tupizeño from the South, as they called him... He sang this song, dedicating it to the bride and groom, the godparents and the guests: with all my love for you all.

A festive song describing the wedding of Anselmo and Marcela in the conventillo, with Doña Martina as godmother (kept in the original Spanish).

El conventillo se ha vestido de amarillo
Adornado con retamas y con cintas de papel.
Aquí en el patio se ha instalado una gran mesa
Bien tendido Dña. Martina la madrina de Anselmo
De los balcones cuelgan globos, serpentinas
Elegante la madrina con manta de alpaca y vicuña
Ahí en la esquina preparada la banda con trompeta,
Batería, un violín bajo trombón
Llegan los novios con los padres y padrinos
Y contentos los vecinos han formado un callejón

Vuelan arroces, serpentinas y misturas y las niñas
Que dulzura que de blanco son un primor
Don Filomeno y Don. Simón los solterones bien sentados
En cajones junto al cura al sacristán y las comadres
Hacen sándwich de chola, elegantes las charolas
Con las copas de champagne
Anselmo Tarqui Pimentel flamante novio
Aprendiz de relojero con taller de callejón
Y la Marcela Catacora hermosa novia firmemente
Enamorada le entrego su corazón
Dña. Martina y Don. Abrahán los padrinos
Que a pesar de su dolor nunca pierden el compas
Y la costumbre como lo hacían antes
Ya los novios elegantes se vienen bailando el vals.
La la.....

When this song ended, there was joy all around, and above all the tears of the bride and groom and of the godmothers, which were nothing but the expression of what everyone at the party felt, and a loud round of applause rose from all who were there. Then a young waiter came by with a tray holding countless little glasses of many colors, and he went up to each of the dancers, who helped themselves eagerly, wishing the newlyweds eternal happiness and that the little ones to come would be their hope and their reason for living... The party went on, and more and more guests kept arriving with many gifts, some with a pair of goats and others with a finely decorated llama. Each time such a gift arrived there was applause, and the band struck up a special rhythm with a very joyful tune. But what was surprising was that the most honored guest of all was Mama Martina. People greeted her with such respect and told her, Mama, you have to be the godmother of my children, because you will bring them great luck and you will also set them on the path of being hardworking and good. Hearing these words, I felt very proud, and at times I felt like shedding a few tears for my lovely grandmother, who never told us who her parents were or what they were like, or how she came to this land. She would say, I am from the valley called Cotagaita, where everything is joy, and the same goes for work. What work her parents did, everything was left half told. The only thing she narrated in full were the carnival festivities (carnestolendas), when people worked

for a whole season just to spend what they earned on this fiesta: clothes, food and the chicha they made. She used to say that nothing had ever made her so happy. But the surprising thing was that she never spoke of her sufferings. She was very brave; she was never sad, and she always had a penetrating gaze, full of the will to win and keep going.

Unexpectedly, Doña Luciana appeared, the wife of Don Félix Ventura, owner of the Huayra silver mill (ingenio), where silver and gold were refined with mercury... She came up very respectfully and said, I found out from one of my workers that you, Doña Martina, were the godmother, and I could not stay away from this occasion, I who owe you so much and will never be able to repay the great favor you did me by saving my husband, and I can confirm that everyone knows you and respects you, more than they do me. Martina answered her, Don't worry, it is important to be at their side; I come to them when they need me, they call me when they are sick or when they need advice... What joy and satisfaction it gives me to hear that, Doña Martina; it comes to me as a recommendation and advice too, and I am very grateful to you... Doña Martina, to keep the joy going I have brought you some lads and a young man who has just arrived from my home region of Valencia, and they will sing you some songs that hold their memories and inspiration... Let me introduce them: they are Milton Cortez and Willy Claire, from the Chaco of your homeland, very well-mannered young men... A pleasure to meet you, Doña Martina, everyone talks about you. And we want to dedicate this song to the bride and groom and, above all, to your esteemed self... It is called...

"Cantarina," a love song the young musicians dedicate to the newlyweds and to Doña Martina (kept in the original Spanish).

C A N T A R I N A

Desde que me vi en tus ojos
Voy de desvelo en desvelo
Con la ilusión de que un día
quieras llevarme a tu cielo
por besar tus labios rojos
por ser parte de tu aliento
dejaría todo, todo porque vengas
a mi encuentro...
desde que cantas mi nombre

cuando me nombra tu boca
voy lloviéndome en tu cuerpo
mientras persigo tu sombra
si la suerte me acompaña
y tu corazón me abriga
viviría abrazado a tus encantos...
vida mía déjame besarte el alma
regalarte mil mañanas bañadas
del canto y el Rosio de mi vos
ven a fundirte a mis brazos
ven a calmar mi dolor
La ra la ra la ra.

What joy and emotion showed in the guests, with their applause and tears. More, more! they cried, what a melody, what verses! And so the party went on until the small hours of the night, as they enjoyed the drinks and the dancing. The time has come for us to leave, tomorrow we have a lot of work, said Doña Martina and Abrahán, taking their leave of all the guests with the greatest respect, amid a thunder of applause and gratitude for their presence....

PART FOUR

Fantasy and Commitment

Chapter 4. ANTONITO'S DAYDREAMS



I remember that early that morning I had promised to go to my uncle Rafael's workshop. He had a job for me, and I showed up faithfully. The work waiting for me was to finish sanding and varnishing some frames that master Nico had ordered. Uncle Rafael told me, if you want to eat, I'm leaving you some quinoa pisara and a little goat cheese, and a little coca tea; help yourself, I have an engagement and I can't miss it... He left in a hurry and didn't say where. I set about sanding the frames very carefully. They were carved in high relief, and I think they had taken him many days. They were of mara wood, and you could see the fineness with which the gouges had been passed over the whole surface, which I had to smooth without losing the angles and edges of the floral work. I wondered how he did it, so I went looking for the chisels and gouges and took a piece of wood with the same grain as the frames. The first thing I did was draw a rose with its branches and other details. I set the gouges along the edges of the drawing, but I couldn't make a cut; it was very

difficult for me. Then I noticed some of my uncle's unfinished pieces, which had vertical cuts, and that lesson showed me that the first thing I had to do was outline the drawing, holding the chisel upright and tapping gently all around the contour. In that way I achieved what I was after, which was to get into the wood, and even so I could barely raise a shaving, because I was using the wrong gouge, completely blunt. I took another one, and with what joy and satisfaction I watched it run and lift the shaving in a spiral! I went on and on patiently until I had cut the whole outline of the rose. Next I did the petals, with such ease, and I enjoyed it; then the stem. I said to myself, no wonder my uncle carves so often, because you forget about time and everything else... Then I came to and asked myself what I was doing... I remembered that I had to finish sanding and begin varnishing. I went back to the earlier job: the sanding still had to be finished, and the glue and the varnish prepared. The varnish had to be applied gently over the whole surface of the frames, then left to dry, and afterwards rubbed little by little until it shone. And so I did, spending the whole morning on it, but I was very satisfied.

One afternoon, on the 22nd of May, the cold wind was blowing down from the summit and the slopes of the mountain. You could hear it whistling as it bent the *paja brava* under the force of that air, and so it reached into the depths of one's soul and bones, leaving hands and face so cold that they brought on a feeling of weariness and sleep. We walked a good stretch and found Nelly at home, very worried about the risks Mama Martina faced with the many sick people she tended, and wishing she would come home as soon as possible. With those thoughts, her hands took up the dough to fry some *buñuelos*, and she was also making an *api* of purple corn. At that moment my brothers Jaime, Ricardo and José Luis appeared... Nelly gave a shout that startled them... Antoñito, I made you what you like best, *buñuelos*, little brother. Today is your birthday, did you forget? Yes... sister, I was busy helping Don Juan, I have to sand some table legs, my arms are sore and I'm very tired. In any case, I thank you with all my heart, sister, you are always mindful of my days and my dreams, I don't know how I can ever repay your help. Once again, my gratitude. Before I forget, Antoñito, uncle Rafael came looking for you to help him; he wants you to visit him at his workshop first thing tomorrow. He was very happy to hear this message; it always brought him something new, an extra job, a task, or a hope, and he was always willing. Thinking and thinking, he went to his bedding on the floor, lay down completely worn out, closed his eyelids and covered himself

with the phullus woven of llama wool, falling into a deep sleep from the weariness of the day.

In his dream, which seemed like reality, he could be seen walking in a great hurry and climbing onto one of the mules of the pack train, which was bound for a very distant destination along far-off roads. He was dressed in very special little clothes: a little vest and a little woolen poncho, white trousers and a little cap with a very prominent tassel, and the whole family was seeing him off: Antoñito, Antoñito. Yanita, may all go well for you, you are going so far away, we hope you come back soon, and I hope you bring news, she said, weeping. Don't cry, he kept repeating, I promise to come back well trained and responsible, he answered, and he too wept in silence, showing his great pain, that pain so intense that every fiber of feeling breaks, because one is parting from those who gave one life and endowed one with every quality, skill, respect and responsibility, and above all with the strength to face the dangers and challenges of life without faltering; and parting too from the brothers and sisters with whom one shared, day and night, joys and sorrows. And now, on this occasion, he was leaving his home without knowing what fate held for him in a faraway place, longing urgently to fulfill his wish to be a carpenter and carver, a painter and a doctor... In the other world, unknown to his eyes, as if his mind could command space, in a very short time, like a flash of lightning, he moved from one place to another, coming to know incredible places and, above all, people: masters who handed him their secrets so that he could carry out certain important tasks, such as curing certain illnesses with plants and minerals. They showed him how, working at the bedside of the gravely ill, who, surprisingly, showed a miraculous recovery on receiving these preparations. Suddenly he found himself in a colorful setting, with gentlemen who looked like monks standing before canvases, holding brushes and boards covered with a multitude of many-colored paints. Facing him were gentlemen with whitish beards, who spoke to him naturally and told him: you must prepare these ochres, panels and cloths, but you must also carry on with your work and your paintings in this same order and technique, and above all you must do it with great love and dedication, transporting yourself in your mind to the very place, as if you were living or feeling those impressions or joys. This craft requires a commitment of mind and body; otherwise it has no value or meaning, if you do not follow these rules. To be a good painter....

He woke with a start, very agitated, his heart pounding, amazed at everything that had happened in his dream. What had happened to him seemed to foretell the paths he would have to travel in his life at the cost of intense sacrifice, but he was not afraid of it and was ready to achieve it no matter what. Then it came back to him, and he remembered that he had an engagement with his uncle Rafael at his workshop, and without losing

THE STORY OF DON FRANCISCO PAULA SÁENZ AND MARÍA

Wake up, wake up, sleepyheads! It was the voice of my sister Nelly. Have your breakfast, we have buñuelos and a tojori that will set you up well for today's work. But first I want to tell you a story that Doña Lalica from the general store told me yesterday, and it happened some years ago. It is about Don Francisco Paula Sáenz. They say he was the son of King Charles III and an Italian princess, whom the King courted in secret; she was very young and beautiful. So that the King's wife would not find out, and to avoid family gossip, they sent his offspring to our land of Potosí with the post of governor, or intendant. When he arrived, he was astonished at the great wealth of the Imperial Town (Villa Imperial) of Potosí. Days and weeks went by. One cold afternoon, with only a few rays of sun, on the street where gentlemen and young men of different origins, generally well-to-do miners or merchants, went to stroll and converse, the so-called Boulevard, a narrow street where one could admire modern, luxurious, many-colored clothes and jewels hanging from the ears, matched with brooches of gold and silver, there stood out among them a very slender, young and enchanting woman, on the arm of an elderly gentleman who was very fortunate for it, and above all for the respect the passersby showed him. People also said he was the owner of the mines of Porco and that he was her father; and sadly they whispered that he kept her in complete isolation. She had everything, but her beautiful face showed loneliness. She devoted herself to household tasks, and her extreme beauty stood out all the more with the gowns and ornaments she wore. Since she had awakened great interest and attraction in him, he found out more and questioned the neighbors, and they confirmed that the man was not her father: he had abducted her from Peru, a descendant of Inca royalty, when she was barely 7 years old. The culprit, who passed himself off as Portuguese, was none other than a Jew named Jacobo Moses. And so the lovely María grew up displaying all her splendor and monumental beauty, and so it was that by chance she met the intendant, Don Francisco, on one of her strolls. They had barely looked at each other when the prince noticed María's beautiful eyes, black and with a sweet gaze, which sent out radiant waves of attraction that made his heart race, beating so hard that it seemed to choke him. The two of them looked at each other and, seconds later, as if by a magic spell or an irresistible harmony, they were drawn together like two poles and ran at the same moment into an embrace so intense, fed by the fire of burning love. But then they pulled

apart forcefully, as though it were an imminent and immense sin or danger.

Many days passed without their seeing each other, but both dreamed day and night of the hour and the day of their next meeting. So the weeks went by, and in secret, in out-of-the-way places, they met and declared their love. And in a soft, whispering voice María said: To love you as I love you is the supreme happiness that cannot be enjoyed here on earth; it is to live for you alone.... And Don Francisco answered her: To love you as I love you is to have no thought but yours, which thinks of me, no heart but yours, which devotes all its beats to me, all its fervent love; to love you as I love you, daughter of a King. So time passed, and both gave their souls and their bodies entirely, with a sincere and pure love. A secret, as they considered it, that was quite impossible to hide; many times their souls had such strength that they could not control them. On one of those many occasions they were seen by people who marveled and whispered among themselves: what will Don Jacobo say if it reaches his ears? He kept her like a jewel so precious that he allowed no one to come near her or to call at his house on any pretext.

When Jacobo Moses learned of María's love affair through the talk and gossip of the neighborhood, and saw besides her indifference and her behavior, he fell into a deep depression. He did not know how to act, until one day he reacted, saying: Oh, I will kill that wretch, and she will die too! He could not carry out his wish; he looked very worn out and unable to go on living with so much suffering. At night María seemed to hear weeping and sobbing, and in his sleep he repeated: no, no, please don't take her from me, she is my life, and without her I will die, she is my breath. A short while later, as usually happens to those who suffer repeated frustrations, such as those marked by the impossible love of a beautiful young woman, he was found, very haggard, hanging lifeless from a rope from one of the beams of his house. So ended the life of Don Jacobo, with riches but without love, which cannot be bought. Feelings such as love, the force of life, are impossible to obtain even with all the wealth in the world.

Years later it became known that they had married and had a son, who was abducted on the orders of the authorities of the town and handed over to the Indigenous group of the Jucumaris, where he was raised and grew up like the natives and was called Juan, or Huallpa Rimachi. The legend tells us that he was the son of Governor Francisco Paola Sáenz

and of María Sawaraura, the Indigenous princess who was abducted by Jacobo at the age of 7. He is known as the guerrilla poet; he was born on June 24, 1793, and died in 1814. Later it was learned that he had been one of the guerrilla fighters of Manuel Ascencio Padilla and Juana Azurduy de Padilla, who were his adoptive parents...

THE WISE MASTER OF PAINTING



The next day, at dawn, Antoñito, with his usual smile, a little boy of about 9, dark-skinned, with a lively gaze, very large black eyes, dark and slightly wavy hair, slim build, nimble in whatever he did, and above all ready to answer any question or to ask about his doubts, remembered that he had an engagement with his uncle Rafael. He got his clothes ready, drank the api his sister had made him, and ran off to his destination. He appeared knocking at the gate and greeting him: good morning, uncle Rafael, you're working hard. Yes, son, how good that you came. I want you to help me sand and varnish these picture frames, and these two coffins; they are needed urgently. The frames are for the

works of Don Melchor Pérez de Holguín and Nicolás Cruz, for the Church of San Francisco. This little job, as you can see, took me a long time to carve. All of this was taught to me by papa Abrahán, whom they have always favored for being very skillful; that is where the recommendation comes from, which Mama Martina got for me when she introduced me to her acquaintance Doña Micaela del Castillo, who is the wife of Don Melchor. They say he is a very demanding and hardworking gentleman; his assistant respects him and, above all, learns a great deal, since he devotes himself to painting and building. It seems he is currently drawing up the plans for the church of San Lorenzo. If you like, you can come with me these days to deliver these works to the Church of San Francisco, where they are painting some pictures. Antoñito, surprised and full of admiration, gave a shout: of course! I'm eager to meet that gentleman they call "Golden Brush." How did you hear about that? I heard some Spaniards say they had seen him painting, in the community of Puna, some canvases of the Virgin's flight into Egypt, and on that occasion they spoke of him by that name, or pseudonym. Ah, uncle Rafael, and these coffins? He answered: I was forgetting, they are orders from Don Agapito, and I'm leaving this for you to earn something: sand it and then varnish it, you're good at that, get to it right now. Without another word I set to work until late at night. I had to do the body and the lid with care. My arms were all numb, I could no longer move them, I felt tired, and I decided to finish the next day and then get on with the varnishing; for that I am preparing the stain, my brushes and the varnish.

The next day, at dawn, I applied the stain to the two coffins, and by midday the varnishing was finished. I was only waiting for uncle Rafael's approval, and afterwards those in charge of the funeral were to take them away.

One Holy Thursday at midday, my uncle Rafael and I were making our way to the Church of San Francisco, carrying the carved, gilded frames. We climbed the steps; my legs were trembling, I began to sweat, and I felt as if I had to face some great ordeal, but my curiosity to meet that gentleman was so great. We passed under the lintel of the second gate and heard a very hoarse voice say, God's good day to you. At that instant my whole body shuddered, and we answered together: good day, Don Nico, how are you? He replied: very well, excellent, I like your punctuality and your work; later I'll show it to the master, he is very busy with the commissions from the Franciscan fathers. After walking a few steps I saw a painting that left me frozen. Look, uncle, who is that saint?

He has such a strong gaze, and he is holding the child; all he lacks is speech. At that moment Don Nico told us: don't talk loudly, it bothers the master. What you are looking at is a commission; it is Saint Matthew the Evangelist, shown writing in his book at the angel's command. I was so struck by the color of the skin, by his expression of a great thinker, as though he were even possessed by another spirit and receiving messages or orders, a mandate that he transcribes with his quills, by the colors of the mantle and all his surroundings, so that it seemed you were inside the picture. Antoñito, what's the matter, you've frozen... Forgive me, Don Nico, how real this painting is.

Don Nico, in a moment of rest while waiting for new orders, began to tell us: Master Melchor is very busy. He is from the valley and paints only on commission. He says he was taught by a Spaniard called Murillo and another called Zurbarán. It is the tata curas (the priests) who trained him and have supported him all along. He says he has lived with the priests since he was very small and received all his guidance and education from them; because of his talents and intelligence they sent him to Spain, where he stayed a long time, coming back already well trained and devoting himself to the fathers' commissions. He traveled everywhere at the demand and request of the churches and of some families of the Viceroy. But what I notice is that some days he falls silent and seems downcast. One afternoon I found him lying on the floor, trembling; he only asked me for hot tea, and you could hear him coughing hard, over and over. I hope it doesn't get worse. I beg him, telling him not to stay up all night, to rest. He doesn't listen to me, he works so much, he doesn't like to go out walking. If something happens to him, what would become of me? Because I have grown used to him and learned a lot from him. What I think is that when we travel by mule day and night it wears him out. Other times we rest along the way, and many times we spend the night in very barren, cold places; we sleep on llama hides to withstand the very low temperatures, and on top of that we don't eat well. Besides, when we prepare his paints we grind earths or ochres and breathe in a lot of dust, above all the one who does the finest part, which has to be to his liking. What is impressive is that when he has new commissions for paintings for the convents and monasteries, he stays shut in his room for days in order to settle his inspirations, which finally become his paintings, which are impressive, like Saint Jerome, Saint Francis of Paola, Saint Matthew and others. When you see them you are very impressed; they look like living people, and they frighten me

a lot, especially when I walk at night. It seems as if they are watching me, and I even think they are accusing me of something, and I start to wonder what wrong I have done...

While I was waiting for my uncle and Don Nico to return, for they had gone to buy some materials, sitting pensively in the doorway, a gentleman of lordly bearing suddenly appeared before me, serious, with a deep gaze, looking almost angry, and he asked me: what are you doing sitting there, boy, who brought you? I had to explain my reasons and why I was in that place. Having heard me, I told him that we had brought the frames that he, sir, had ordered. He calmed down and, with a smile, answered me in a hoarse, confident voice: for many years I have not had the chance to talk with someone your age, and I like it, I even feel a spiritual peace. At that instant I took the opportunity to ask him: Master, Master, and where did you learn to paint these marvels, marvels... Don't be surprised, son; they are the expression of what is inside me, and I do it with such love and commitment because I live that reality with them. No wonder, Master, it seemed to me they really look at you, and all that's missing is for them to ask me something. Ha, ha, they are saints of the holy book, and commissions from the church. As I told you, I feel at peace, and I can tell you a little of my story. It began many years ago, when I was very small. It seems I was born in the church; for as long as I can remember I was always with the tata curas. I liked to draw, and that was the reason why, at your age, the fathers sent me to Spain on a ship, bound for a convent that was a school of art. There I stayed and met my master Bartolomé. For the first years I had no contact with him, only with his disciples, who were older men, such as Meneses and Osorio. They gave all of us who were beginners the task of grinding ochres of many colors and mixing them with oils, from the dark colors to the light ones, warm as well as cool. They were so demanding about the fineness of the grinding of the terracottas that the work necessarily went on to be graded or approved by other senior men, almost next in rank to the master, and sometimes it was rejected at the very moment it was being applied to the canvases. Once this stage of tasks was over and done, only then did we devote ourselves to drawing sketches on cloths, which we had to clean in order to use them again. After 6 years of this work, only then did I come close to the master, and it was possible thanks to the recommendation given to him by the Franciscan father who made the voyages to the Americas, accompanying the Spanish sailors who carried slaves on the King's orders.



My first use of the brush, with so much fear, was with Maestro Meneses. He guided me very well, and many times he asked me to paint certain segments, valuing my skill above all, though I was not to mention it to my companions. And so it went on, year after year, until I had great dexterity; I took advantage of the master's absences. He traveled a great deal, his presence was requested in other places, and we did not see him for long stretches. My master used to say that rich people from many countries made great demands of him. And so the years went by. I felt very happy to be fulfilling my dreams and doing what I longed to do. This is part of what I did and learned... well, up to now that I have told it to you, and I don't know why, and I don't even know your name or where you are from... Forgive me, maestro, my name is Antoñito, I am the grandson of Doña Martina and the nephew of Don Rafael, the master carpenter. Yes, I already know him through his works, which are fantastic. And your parents... Don Primo and Mama Catalina. How wonderful. Respect them and love them above all things; time passes, and so often we cannot value what we have and what they did for us. Don't forget, come and visit me. I am glad to have shared these

moments; come whenever you like. Thank you very much, maestro, for me it is a joy to meet you, and above all an honor. No, the honor is mine... And deep inside I kept repeating, how wise this gentleman is, what an intense satisfaction. That soft voice echoed in my mind again and again, and I felt as if I were walking on clouds. I am glad to have shared these moments, come whenever you like... that is, I was as if I were dreaming, dreaming, and suddenly I sensed a silence and saw him leaning back in his armchair, in a deep sleep. He looked very worn out, and I stayed there contemplating his figure. After a while I heard the footsteps and voices of my uncle and Don Nico, who was surprised to see him beside me. Don't make any noise, let him rest, he is very tired, he works until very late. In any case, boy, thank you very much for looking after him. We left at once, and he reminded my uncle to be ready for any call. We walked a long way in silence, and he asked me, did you talk with the maestro? And with some effort I answered yes. What did he talk to you about? And I told him: about his art and where he was trained. For me it was a marvel and an honor that he spoke with me. How good, Antoñito, may it serve you as a lesson for life. Thank you, uncle, thank you for taking me to meet these honorable gentlemen, so honest and so humble...

Days later, he still could not forget, and Maestro Holguín's words kept resounding in his mind.



All in a hurry, he went to San Francisco and looked for Don Nico. Please, señor, I would like to ask you a favor... What's the matter, boy? I want to bring the gentleman a present... something my mama

Martina made... I'll ask, and you come tomorrow before he starts his work... Very well, Don Nico. At dawn he prepared his little bag with the buñuelos his sister Nelly had made for him and set off for the church. He turned the handle, and Don Nico, with some effort, opened the great door with a dull creak. Come in, son, come in. He is at the end of the corridor... Thank you, Don Nico... It was a workshop lit brightly by candles. Good morning, maestro, I have brought you this present, some buñuelos. Why, son, what is this? They look delicious, and they're warm, let me try one... how delicious, you'll have to bring me some often... Yes, maestro... Last time you told me you would like to be a painter. You are someone I trust deeply. You know, painting is not only imitating form, but giving a voice to the silence of our ancestors. Every brushstroke is also an act... of memory of life itself, and color reminds me that all true learning is born of sensitivity and respect for those who came before us. Therefore every painting expresses the secret and the wisdom of those

who lived before. In the same way he spoke of the lives of the ancestors and of the value of connecting what is seen with what is not seen. He taught me that teachings are carried across time, and that the memory of the past lives in every gesture and every thought. I could understand very little of it at that moment.

Mama Martina's dreams and her real life met in that last memory: the inheritance of love, of memory and of wisdom. Antonito understood that every act of respect and affection toward our ancestors is also an act of creation and continuity. I am because they were, and I will be for as long as I remember them....

THE TREASURE OF DON FRANCISCO ROCHA



It was the year 1642 in the Villa Imperial, which was at the height of its mining boom. At that time the silver mills (ingenios) covered the slopes of the mountain and both banks of the river, rising above massive granite walls. In the towers turned the master wheel and the iron balls that ground to powder the ore extracted from the mines. The owner of Thuru Cancha, one of the finest mills along the river, was Don Francisco Rocha. And he was not truly a Don... because that title had not been

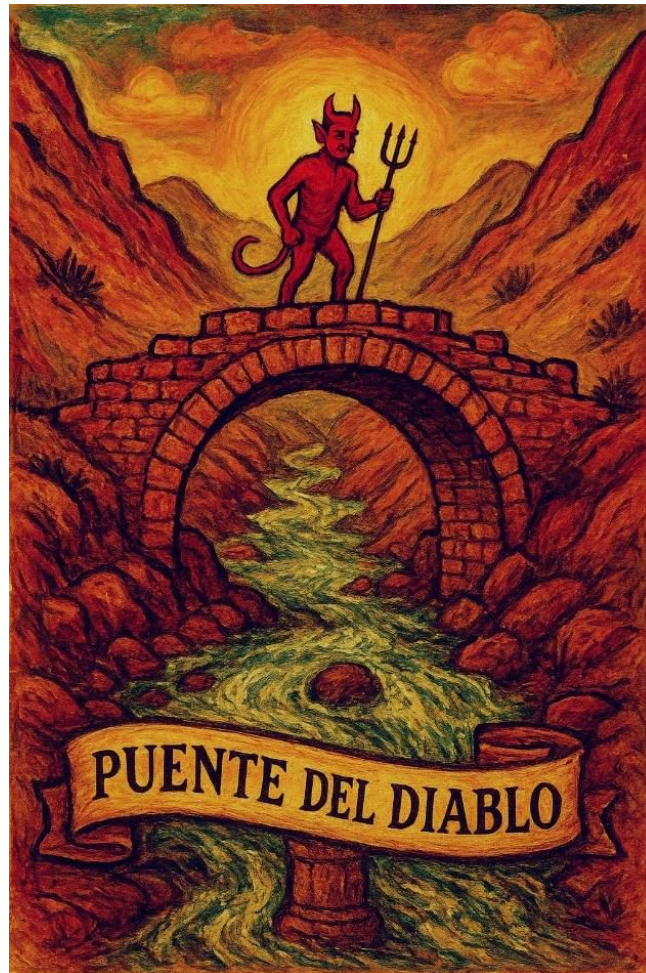
granted to him by the Sovereign Will of the Monarch, but because he had a great deal of money, which took the place of the parchments that purified Plebeian blood. He was content with his blood: if it was not the blue blood of the Nobility, it was the red blood of the descendants of Tupac Katari. He could have covered every street and square of Potosí with silver, and what set him apart was that he was very generous and humble with the poor and with the Indians. They say that Don Francisco Rocha was a miner and silver merchant, a counterfeiter of coins; they considered him an adventurer, because he defied the Church and the Crown in his wish to change history, trying to correct wrongdoing and to make his own justice. He tried to improve the lives of the Indigenous people, but in doing so he also made Basque enemies. It is said that he was responsible for diverting to his own storehouses half of the silver that was supposed to be carried to the mint in Argentina. The townspeople swear that he had dealings with little goblins; some say they heard voices and the tramp of horses. The rich despised him because they doubted the source of his wealth; besides, he was a young man of mestizo origin whose fortune was dazzling, and their hatred grew all the more because he lived with a very beautiful Indian woman named Koricosichi. His dearest collaborators were Satuko, an Indigenous leader, and Quemar, an African prince captured as a slave by Spanish bands. One fine day, while Don Francisco Rocha was doing his shopping in the town, he was dazzled by a lady newly arrived from Spain. Making use of his gifts as a Don Juan and his skills as a gallant, he managed to make her his sweetheart, and she, very worldly and ambitious, went along with his requests and his offers to give her everything she might desire: pearls, diamonds and gold. Then one night she accepted what he had promised, and he took her in a carriage, her eyes covered with a scarf, on a journey with no known direction. She could only hear the mules galloping over the cobblestones, a sound that later grew hoarser, and finally the noise of a great door opening. They went on for a while longer in the darkness, and she was consumed by curiosity about where he was taking her. At last the scarf was removed, and in her amazement all she could do was let out a cry: they had entered his cave, and with great surprise she saw an immense treasure, chests of gold and silver coins, scattered brilliants and dunes of silver. He offered to give her the very best if she would be his companion, and as a token of his esteem she received a gold jewel set with brilliants. But she, not satisfied and with a cunning spirit, was very pensive throughout the return journey, on which her face was again covered so that she could never remember the

direction or the route to the place she had been. After leaving that place she was set down in a very narrow street, from which she made her way to her lodging. Without losing any time, and in keeping with agreements made with her patrons, she went to a group of Basques and told them everything that had happened, step by step, detail by detail, the whole course of the journey on which she had seen such riches. Her listeners were left open-mouthed, and, driven even more by their own greed, they denounced him to the authorities, who had long been trying to capture him. One day, when that woman had arranged to meet him, he was taken prisoner on the grave charge of COUNTERFEITING COINS. Rocha, astonished and angry, was taken to the premises of that court, where, ruled by hatred and envy, they decided swiftly and capriciously on the harshest and most exemplary punishment, and he was then sentenced to death by all those Basque enemies. In the name of the Crown he was executed: they hanged him and left him lying in the street, where many days later he was taken up by his wife. How great was her shock to see her beloved utterly disfigured, covered in wounds, his neck shattered, already showing signs of decay. Taking advantage of the night, and above all because no one passed that way, she lifted him and took him in her arms as if her beloved's weight were nothing, and carried him in a wooden cart, covering him with her shawl, amid sobs and weeping, swearing again and again that she would take revenge on those who had committed such a crime. The echo of her weeping and her cries rang through the darkness and against the great mountain walls, and, as if they understood, some foxes and other animals could be heard howling. When she reached their hideaway, he was laid on a carved stone inlaid with gold and silver that sometimes served as a table on which to set down saddlebags, blankets, saddles and the gear of their journeys. She embraced him and screamed in despair, her cries resounding through the cave, and she told her helpers to find the herbs and powders to care for the remains of her lord. Without even noticing how much time had passed, the widow was woken by the servant, who told her that everything was ready to be applied to Don Francisco's body. There was a very pleasant scent of mint and of other plants known only to her people. Alone, her eyelids badly swollen, she undressed the body, bathed it and applied the powders over every part of it, so that no one would learn the secret and the skill with which her beloved was preserved. Afterward he was dressed in his finest clothes, embroidered with threads of silver and gold, and surrounded with part of his treasures and diamonds, which sparkled in the light of the torches placed beside

him. It was at that moment that her mind filled with how to begin her revenge. Weeping as she-wolves do when they have lost their mate, she took her hair, which fell to her waist, black and gleaming like jet, as the ñustas (Inca princesses) wear it, or ccoricusichi, as her beloved used to call her. Taking a sharp knife, she cut it from the nape of her neck, gathering it from both sides, and hour after hour, taking lock after lock and pouring all her rage into it, she wove a very long rope, as strong as the chumpis (woven belts) that hold the ore for carrying. This will be the rope with which she pays for my suffering, she who robbed me of my hope, for whom I lost my whole world and my dreams. I swear by my gods that for what she took from me, my light, my dream, my path, my companion, I will take my revenge, and I will do it very soon. One night, driven by rage and grief, she set out for the town by the chosen, secret path, in a carriage, dressed in her beloved's clothes. She left the carriage on the outskirts, and for days she asked questions and watched the house of the woman who had caused her beloved to be seized by the guards and his enemies. And one night, when she was already physically exhausted, she recognized her and followed her, creeping up as stealthily as a leopard, and with all her strength she covered the woman's face and threatened her with death if she called for help. The woman resisted, and she struck her a hard blow that knocked her unconscious; then she carried her on her shoulders like a load of ore to the carriage, where she covered her and tied her hands and feet. So the lady who had caused it all was kidnapped and taken to the cave, where the remains of her beloved lay in vigil. Between tears and rage, with great effort, she sealed the entrance of the cave in the mountain with rocks and lime mortar, repeating insistently to her prisoner: you will die here with me, you deceived him, you lied out of greed, you were the cause of the death of my beloved, my dear one, my Francisco. From that day on, no one has ever known where Rocha's treasure lies. Every Potosí resident, whenever a wall is knocked down or the ground is dug up, hopes to come upon Rocha's treasure, or a tapado (a hidden cache), or some concealed colonial treasure that might be recovered at any moment: the wealth that great Potosí possessed, which lies beneath the earth and which other greedy outsiders could never get their hands on. But Rocha hid it and kept it for himself, in his house, they say, in a cave or in a house with a second courtyard, beneath a dome that stands in the village of Mondragón, a place that comes alive thanks to this treasure. And they even tell that the priest and the sacristan found it and were lost in the Devil's Cave. Some residents say the Tapado lies roughly 18

kilometers from the city, near the lagoons of Tarapaya and the Devil's Cave. (Sketch of the area.) From that date and year onward, locals and outsiders alike have searched for this treasure.

THE DEVIL'S BRIDGE



Jaime and Ricardo, the older brothers, were very busy and could not be present at the prize-giving, which was considered the most important one, because they had set aside those days for some mining work and, above all, to accompany their friends Alfredo Buhezo, Willy Varela and Walter Morales, who were devoted to searching for the traces, the trail left by the people close to the richest miner of all, Francisco Rocha, who had always boasted of owning brilliants, jewels, diamonds and gold and silver coins, and who had many times promised the people of the Villa that he would adorn the streets with silver, just to obtain the rank of gentleman. This was one of their goals: to find, by any means, ROCHA'S TREASURE... They would disappear for several days and turn up with pale faces and grown thin, which was a great worry for their parents.

Each time they were asked, they repeated that they had been out in the Mondragón area, where Varela's father had his fields of corn, broad beans and potatoes, which were brought into town to be sold and eaten. That was only an excuse. As soon as day broke, their thoughts were wholly devoted to, or taken up with, being in the area of the Devil's Bridge, believing from rumors that it would be the place where one of the objects of their search was to be found. Others were drawn by the tapados, the hidden caches or chests that Spaniards had buried when they left Potosí for a time and, often for all sorts of reasons, never came back, so that they were forgotten. These riches were the focus not only of their attention but of many fortune seekers, just as in the days of mining and silver. For them it was a way to improve their economic situation, which had always been a great worry for their parents. They saw with their own eyes how their parents earned a living with great sacrifice and risk: risk from the work they did, while their pay did not justify the effort they made. They worked in the mines all day long, and their fortnightly wages barely covered food and a few clothes. Sometimes they would repeat what they thought: education is good, but it does not answer our needs.

Speaking of the Devil's Bridge, a place where the local people prayed as they crossed, especially as night was falling, what no doubt came to mind was one of the events the old people of the area used to tell, from which the place takes its name, the result of a story that happened there.

In the group of explorers, so as not to take the wrong paths, as had often happened to them, they asked for the help of one of the farmhands, who knew every imaginable corner of the region. They called him Albertico, and just as they reached the Devil's Bridge he would begin to tell one of the legends of the region, a love story between two young people. On hearing these words, they say, the whole group drew close and paid attention as never before, far more than to their parents' advice. He would begin, as all legends do, by saying: there was once a very handsome young peasant who fell in love with a very beautiful girl, the daughter of the corregidor (magistrate), and they saw each other in secret. But one day they were discovered by her father, who threatened him and laid down the following demand: if you want my daughter, you must pay me her dowry, which is this amount of silver, within one year; otherwise you will never see her again. I do this because I have heard that you work hard and well, never forgetting what family you come from. This time starts today. In that very short time, the suitor pledged to keep

this promise, and to do so he began to work at many things, as a miner, a helper, a carrier of ore. And up close he saw how the workers labored, facing many dangers: cave-ins, falls into mine shafts, and often being trapped in the workings. And most surprising of all, they ate almost nothing; they only chewed coca, which allowed them to work without tiring. And on one of those afternoons he saw the remains of a miner brought out after an accident, and heard the endless weeping of his small children and his wife, which truly awakened an intense sadness. A year later, having earned the dowry, on the day of his return with what he had earned, to fulfill the agreement with his sweetheart's father, he set out with his donkey and came to a ravine he had to cross. Suddenly the sky turned dark, as if to foretell a conflict; thunder crashed, and lightning lit up the whole place, and a torrential rain began, with the roar of waterfalls and the grinding of rocks being swept along, numbing the senses. And he asked himself: what am I going to do now, how will I reach the town, it is impossible to cross, what can I do? Her father will not believe my word, and it will be his reason to forbid me to see her. In his despair an uncontrollable rage rose in him; he kicked the rocks and pounded the edge of the gorge, weeping, shouting, amid lightning and a terrifying, overwhelming din. What can I do now? I feel powerless and I have no hope left. And finally, into his confused mind, with no other choice or option left, came the idea of asking the devil for help, and in a loud voice he spoke the following words: [I would even give my soul if he would help me build a bridge. At that very instant, to his great surprise, the devil appeared with a thunderous crash and a certain smell of burnt sulfur, standing right before him, with a hoarse voice that grated on the ears and an air of arrogance and self-assurance, hearing his request. What do you want from me, why did you call me? You know that if I do it, it is on one condition: when I finish what you ask, I will take your soul. The young man told him: build a stone bridge. And without further ado he accepted, on that condition: if it is finished by dawn, before the rooster crows, my soul will be yours. I agree, but keep it in mind... before the rooster crows... It's a deal. In his extreme haste the devil cut the stones and set to work as if he were dozens of workers building the bridge. The young man, calmer and more at peace, began to reflect and realized the mistake he had made, and he asked God for help: Lord, forgive me for this act; I didn't know what to do in my haste, and my anxiety made me commit this madness. Please help this poor son of yours who is caught in this misfortune. And suddenly he perceived a sign, white like a radiance: the archangel Saint Gabriel. At that moment there was a clap

of thunder and a flash of lightning, and he wondered, could this be the sign my Lord is giving me? Then he felt a shudder run through his body, and an inner peace, no longer the despair that had gripped him. Suddenly, on the horizon, there were signs that dawn would soon come. He saw the devil hurrying to take the last stones to finish the edges of the bridge, and suddenly many angels appeared who kept the devil from lifting the stones and setting the final stage in place to complete it. And far off could be heard the sharp sound of the rooster's first crow at dawn. The demon, defeated, spitting sparks and thunder, vanished into the infinite, saying: I will not forgive you.. In this way the young man saved his soul, and the bridge was left unfinished, but it no longer kept him from fulfilling his promise of the silver. And so his pledge was fulfilled, and with it the couple's dream came true: the marriage of the two young people, who lived happily for a long time, with several children.

PART FIVE

The End

Chapter 5. THE FAREWELL OF DOÑA MARTINA, THE MIDWIFE



Weary now from her labors and from caring for her family, Doña Martina and her husband, Don Abrahán, decide to set out on a very long journey. But first they gather all the members of the family at their house, as was their custom, to share some lamb broth and chicha prepared by the expert hands of the lady of the house. Rafael, the eldest son, cheerful as always, turns up with some of his friends from work, armed with their string instruments and small drums, and they sing with one voice, in high and low tones, and this is how it went.

A sorrowful love song of heartbreak and longing that Rafael and his friends sing at the farewell gathering (kept in the original Spanish).

Un puñal envenenado atravesaste mi pecho
Ondas huellas has dejado en mi corazón desecho de amor
Ondas huellas has dejado en mi corazón desecho de amor
Al cielo pido la muerte y él no me la quiere dar
Me parece que hasta el cielo se goza y se goza de verme llorar
Dime si me quieres o si voluntad me tienes
Dime, dime si me quieres o si voluntad me tienes
Donde caben voluntades el amor ya puede caber.

I dedicate this song to my mamita Martina. Ever since I was little, I remember, I always saw her working, day and night. It didn't matter if it was cold or raining, she went out and came back in the early hours of the morning, all worn out, and always, always with her gifts: a lamb, some hens, or her fruit. The same with my papa Abrahán, with his carpentry and carving work, which I learned from him, and with what patience he taught me! Today I can earn my living and make my way with it. To them we dedicate these two songs, and as I try to begin, my throat tears apart and I feel like crying out loud, but today I will be brave. With all my heart I dedicate these two songs.

A tender song about a gentle, loving father, which Rafael dedicates to his parents Martina and Abrahán (kept in the original Spanish).

El pintaba paredes y otro lucia
El pintaba la cuna que yo dormía
Y cantaba bajito acariciando
Valsecitos milongas y algunos tangos
Y cantaba bajito acariciando
El mateaba debajo del limonero
Los domingos de junio de abril a enero
Y miraba la vida desde una sonrisa
Enseñaba a vivir la vida con valentía
Él hablaba el idioma de la ternura
Con pocas palabras y mil dulzuras
Pero siempre recuerdo a lo lejos

It surprises me that at just one word of invitation you have all come to my farewell. I see my comadres, my godchildren, my neighbors, and also Doña Casimira and her relatives. You have all filled me with your gifts and food. Thank you all. But what is happening? I see some of you crying, with such sad faces. Don't be like that, you'll make even me and Abrahán cry. This moment of farewell had to come sooner or later. We still have strength and, above all, the fighting spirit we won in this holy land, where my children were born, and my dreams, and I am above all proud to have earned the esteem and affection of each one of you.

You all know my Rafito. With his music and singing, he tried to express his feelings of love and, of course, of sadness; you can see it in his tears over our leaving. He and my daughters should feel happy, because they have been the reason for our lives. We have given them all our love and sacrifice. Above all, they have seen and felt how we faced very sad and hard situations, which all of us endured in our own flesh: they, deprived of our presence, responsible for the food and for supporting their brothers and sisters together; we, doing our part to settle everything that was pending day after day, many times receiving only water. We came back with joy and above all with hope, and all of that was reflected in our children, who welcomed us with laughter and tears. That is how we have shaped them, with dreams, joy, sadness, effort, failure, stumbling and getting up again with the same strength, and guided them along the path they should follow according to their own outlook and interests. They are strong and able to face any setback. I also want to take this moment to praise and admire my son-grandson Antoñito, who from a very young age showed every interest in being by our side, offering himself for any task, helping his grandfather Abrahán as best he could, learning the skills of carpentry and carving. And with me, what can I say, he would not leave my side. He followed me to watch how I treated the sick and to walk long distances for long stretches of time. Afterwards you could see how tired he was, and in his little voice he would tell me, Mamita, I can't go on, my little feet hurt. We took the chance to rest and eat our mote de haba and piri. After our rest we managed to pick out and gather many plants, roots and medicinal earths. We came back from that walk much calmer, as I explained to him what they were for and how they were prepared. He asked questions all the time, he was never quiet, and we were satisfied at having found and obtained what we needed for our purposes. What a joy to see my comadres, neighbors and close friends who were my patients come to this, my request and my farewell. All of

you, sooner or later, will have to follow the same path, a path we have walked day after day, with or without guidance, with hardships or great satisfactions. I don't want to remember my childhood. The only thing I can tell you is that I worked and learned a great deal, from people, from Doña Aurora de la Cruz, from the old world of Toledo, whom I consider my mother. My parents, whom I lost tragically, loved me very much. I am the product, the result, of my character and my perseverance. I also took on the habits and customs of the local people, which, of course, I passed on to my family.

All those present fell silent, and some were weeping, their faces full of sadness. From the crowd one of them rose and, in a broken voice, said, Doña Martina, we consider you a mother. Every time we came to you, by day or by night, you never turned down our request, whether for health, for advice, or even for food. Today, as you leave us, you leave us with a very deep sorrow. We greatly admire the family you leave behind, and we do not doubt that they will fill your absence. Not all of us are here today; wherever we go, people ask about you, Mama Martina. Our eternal gratitude, may the Lord be with you, and from afar pray for us. Each of us carries you in our heart and soul. May you live forever.... So ended this gathering, and everyone said goodbye slowly, down to the very last, in the gloom of the night.

At dawn, after giving a kiss to each of their children, who were sound asleep, they set out on a road to no fixed destination, never to return.....



NOTE OF CLARIFICATION, ACKNOWLEDGMENT AND DEDICATION

This history, tale and legend, which goes back to the years 1600 to 1800 in the Imperial Town (Villa Imperial) of Potosí and the mines of Atocha and Tela Mayo, Tupiza and Tasna, is nothing more than the transcription of what my grandparents, Doña Martina and Abrahán, lived through... It is a partial compilation from Spanish literature, from the Potosí chronicler Bartolomé Arzans in his book History of the Imperial Town of 1705, from the chronicles of Potosí, and from the tale and legend of the dreams and fantasies of the protagonists who recounted all the events of the past and the paths they followed in these rich lands so full of history. May it remain in our memory as a memorable past of effort and sacrifice, remembering our forebears with affection and respect, so that it is not forgotten and endures through time. National songs and songs from northern Argentina are also included, which tell and interpret the reality of those times with simplicity and deep feeling. My thanks for this to everyone who has contributed to this work, dedicated to my grandparents, my parents and my dear and unforgettable family... May 1, 2020. Buenos Aires–Cochabamba.

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